When Do Voters Punish Corrupt Candidates? Evidence from Hungary *

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Abstract

When do voters tolerate corruption, and how do they respond to it? Using a conjoint experiment conducted before the 2024 elections in Hungary, this study examines three stages of corruption voting: information acquisition, evaluation under mitigating conditions, and behavioral response. We find that source credibility is particularly important for core partisans and politically engaged voters during information acquisition. Regarding mitigating conditions, partisan loyalty substantially shields co-partisan corrupt candidates from electoral punishment, while voters are more likely to sanction corruption that lacks tangible benefits such as job creation. Finally, we show that loyalty toward corrupt in-party candidates remains strong even when clean opposition alternatives are available. However, the moderate decline in support is primarily driven by abstention rather than vote switching.

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1 Introduction

Competitive elections establish a system that enables voters to hold policymakers accountable for their decisions and actions. While, according to democratic theory, elections provide voters with a mechanism to remove corrupt candidates from office (Przeworski, Stokes, and Manin 1999), empirical tests of this expectation have produced inconclusive results.

A substantial body of research explains variation in electoral accountability for corruption through institutional factors such as the electoral system, district magnitude, and clarity of responsibility (Chang and Golden 2007; Tavits 2007). These accounts assume that voters would punish corruption if institutions enabled them to do so. More recent scholarship challenges this premise, pointing instead to mitigating factors such as the availability of information (Winters and Weitz-Shapiro 2013; Chong et al. 2015), the credibility of its source (Botero et al. 2015; Weitz-Shapiro and Winters 2017; Winters and Weitz-Shapiro 2020), and voters' tolerance of corruption when offset by perceived competence—whether in economic growth (Klašnja and Tucker 2013), policy performance (Konstantinidis and Xezonakis 2013), or direct material benefits such as jobs (Klašnja, Lupu, and Tucker 2021), social transfers (Mares and Visconti 2020), or even security (García-Ponce, Zeitzoff, and Wantchekon 2021). Scholars also highlight group-serving biases in accountability, linked to partisan in-groups (Anduiza, Gallego, and Muñoz 2013) as well as broader identities of language, ethnicity, or religion (Solaz, De Vries, and De Geus 2019).

Yet most studies examine these mechanisms in isolation, even though voters in real elections weigh multiple, intersecting trade-offs, and these trade-offs – as well as the relative importance of one factor over another – vary across individuals. As De Vries and Solaz (2017) argue, corruption's electoral effects unfold in three stages – information acquisition, blame attribution, and behavioral response – and "when one or more of these

steps break down, the electoral punishment of corrupt politicians might not happen" (De Vries and Solaz 2017, p. 396). Yet, they note, existing research has rarely engaged with this framework explicitly.

In this paper, we empirically investigate the conditions under which voters sanction or tolerate corruption. We engage with all three stages of the corruption voting process: (1) the role of information source credibility, (2) the effect of instrumental incentives and social identities as mitigating conditions, and (3) the resulting (declared) behavioral responses – whether voters continue to support a corrupt co-partisan (sticking), switch to another party (switching), or choose to abstain from voting altogether.[1]

Drawing on original conjoint survey data from Hungary, our study yields four main findings. First, at the information acquisition stage, we show that source credibility significantly influences corruption assessments among core partisans and politically interested voters – suggesting that engagement with information is filtered through political identity and interest. Second, we test the mitigating effects of partisanship and show that when a candidate from the respondent's preferred party is corrupt, voters exhibit limited electoral sanctioning: although support decreases, corrupt co-partisan candidates remain significantly more likely to be selected than non-corrupt candidates with random attributes. Third, we show that poor voters and those residing in high-unemployment settlements sanction corruption more harshly when the corrupt act fails to deliver tangible community benefits, such as job creation. Fourth, in terms of behavioral responses, while corruption among in-party candidates decreases the likelihood of continued support, partisan loyalty nonetheless remains remarkably strong—even when voters are presented with a clean opposition alternative. The decline in support stems mainly from abstention rather than

[1] In this terminology, we follow De Vries and Solaz (2017) – whose framework echoes Lazarsfeld, Berelson, and Gaudet (1944)' distinction between conversion, activation, and reinforcement. We refer to the third stage as the behavioral response, noting that in our survey-based analysis it reflects a *declared* rather than actual response.

switching, with evidence of abstention persisting even in the presence of a clean opposition candidate. Taken together, our findings show how accountability mechanisms falter when partisanship, material incentives, and limited electoral alternatives blunt the impact of corruption concerns, while also revealing which groups are most responsive to specific mitigating factors and how they adjust their behavior in the face of corruption.

Our findings make three main contributions to the literature on corruption voting, democratic accountability, and political preference formation. First, we advance research on behavioral responses to corruption by examining how they are shaped by the availability of clean alternatives, partisan loyalty, and their interaction (Klašnja, Lupu, and Tucker 2021; Bågenholm and Charron 2015; Agerberg 2020). Our design allows us to disentangle whether declines in support for a corrupt in-party candidate lead to abstention or preference switching, and how these responses are conditioned by the presence of a clean alternative.

These distinctions are normatively important. If reduced support for a corrupt in-party candidate leads voters to switch to a clean, albeit ideologically distant, opposition candidate, this outcome strengthens democratic accountability by incentivizing politicians to remain clean and signaling that integrity can attract voters across partisan divides. By contrast, if reduced support instead translates into abstention, this reflects political disillusionment and apathy, lowering participation in core democratic practices such as voting and potentially fostering undemocratic dynamics. Moreover, when corruption is not punished by shifting support to clean alternatives, its electoral costs remain limited, thereby weakening politicians' incentives to avoid corrupt practices.

Second, we contribute to the empirical literature on corruption voting by examining all three stages of corruption voting – information acquisition, evaluation under mitigating conditions, and behavioral response –, thereby testing the theoretical framework advanced by De Vries and Solaz (2017). We not only show how various mitigating factors shape cor-

ruption voting, but also demonstrate that their relative weight varies across social groups within the same society. We therefore argue that a holistic understanding of corruption punishment requires attention both to the circumstances under which mitigating factors operate and to the social groups most responsive to them.

Third, we link individual-level survey data with administrative data at the settlement level – the smallest administrative unit in Hungary – to examine how voters' responses to corruption interact with local economic conditions. This linkage allows us to assess how these conditions shape corruption-related electoral choices, particularly when corruption is associated with or occurs without job creation. Using objective unemployment data at this fine level of aggregation mitigates common limitations of survey-based measures, such as social desirability bias in self-reported employment and attenuation bias in perceived local economic conditions. In doing so, we contribute to research on how corruption affects economically vulnerable populations (Justesen and Manzetti 2023) and complement studies that integrate survey data with objective local indicators (Pepinsky, Reiff, and Szabó 2024).

We study these dynamics in Hungary, an ideal context for examining corruption voting. Hungary consistently ranks as the most corrupt EU member state (Transparency 2024). Public perceptions reflect this: 88% of Hungarians believe corruption is widespread (compared to the EU average of 68%) and 51% think it has increased in the past three years (Eurobarometer 2024). Yet corruption carries little political cost: politicians from both government- and opposition-supported parties facing well-documented or proven allegations often remain in office. Although Hungary is widely viewed as a democratic backslider and competitive authoritarian regime, elections still provide citizens with the opportunity to remove corrupt leaders. Combined with a highly polarized media environment and the centrality of partisanship as a key social identity, these conditions make Hungary a compelling context for studying how and when voters respond to corruption.

2 The Electoral Consequences of Corruption

Competitive elections are a fundamental mechanism of accountability, enabling citizens to periodically evaluate government performance and to sanction or reward incumbents accordingly (Fearon 1999). In principle, this mechanism should discipline poorly performing officeholders, including those engaged in corruption. Yet a growing body of empirical research finds that voters in a wide range of contexts often impose weak or no electoral sanctions on corrupt politicians (Incerti 2020).

Much of the earlier literature explains variation in electoral accountability for corruption by pointing to institutional factors, such as the electoral system, district magnitude, or the clarity of responsibility (Chang and Golden 2007; Tavits 2007). These accounts assume that voters are naturally inclined to punish corruption when institutions enable clear attribution of responsibility.

Recent scholarship challenges the assumption that voters sanction corrupt politicians whenever they are able to, instead highlighting a range of mitigating factors that condition the likelihood of electoral punishment. In their excellent review, De Vries and Solaz (2017) present a schematic framework for understanding the processes through which corruption may – or may not – translate into electoral consequences. Their account disaggregates the mechanism of corruption sanctioning into three distinct stages. First, voters may lack access to credible or sufficient information about corrupt behavior. Second, voters must engage in blame attribution by assigning causal responsibility and determining which public officials are to blame for specific events or outcomes. Third, even when voters are informed and able to assign responsibility, they may respond in different ways at the ballot box, such as switching their vote, abstaining, or continuing to support the incumbent.

First, information acquisition is central to shaping electoral accountability for corruption, since accountability is first and foremost conditional on the information available to

voters (Ferraz and Finan 2008). Several factors can constrain the dissemination of information, including efforts by politicians to obscure corrupt practices, restricted or biased media reporting, government influence over media outlets, widespread illiteracy, and weak judicial enforcement or lack of prosecutions.

Even when information is available and corruption is reported, voters may discount it if they regard the source – such as media outlets or judicial institutions – as lacking credibility (Winters and Weitz-Shapiro 2013; Chong et al. 2015). The credibility of the source is therefore pivotal in determining whether citizens update their beliefs and respond to corruption cues (Weitz-Shapiro and Winters 2017; Winters and Weitz-Shapiro 2020; Botero et al. 2015; Mares and Visconti 2020).[2]

Information about corruption, on its own, is not a sufficient condition for voters to adjust their electoral preferences (De Vries and Solaz 2017). Voters may prioritize alternative considerations, such as material benefits or social identity, that influence their willingness to sanction corrupt politicians, either consciously or unconsciously. In the context of corruption, citizens often engage in implicit trade-offs, weighing their evaluations of corrupt behavior against other perceived benefits (Rundquist, Strom, and Peters 1977). Research shows that voters may overlook corruption when it is accompanied by tangible gains, such as strong economic performance (Klašnja and Tucker 2013; Breitenstein 2019), the provision of direct goods and services (Mares and Visconti 2020), or improvements in welfare delivery (Fernández-Vázquez, Barberá, and Rivero 2016). Similarly, Klašnja, Lupu, and Tucker (2021) find that voters may prioritize side-benefits generated through corrupt practices – such as job creation – over concerns about integrity.[3]

[2] Ares, Breitenstein, and Hernández (2024) show that voters' selective exposure further limits information availability and credibility, as they avoid disconfirming content about their preferred party.

[3] However, empirical support for the performance–corruption trade-off is inconsistent: voters often report willingness to punish corrupt politicians regardless of performance (Winters and Weitz-Shapiro 2013; Breitenstein and Hernández 2024), though this may depend on the officeholder's rank (Zhu and Yang 2023).

Much of this literature converges on the view that *partisanship* plays a central role in voters' instrumental evaluations, operating as a "running tally" that reflects perceptions of party performance, ideological orientation, and policy proximity (Justesen and Manzetti 2023; Solaz, De Vries, and De Geus 2019). These patterns are consistent with theories of motivated reasoning, whereby voters process information in ways that reinforce their prior beliefs and preferences (Taber and Lodge 2006).

However, partisanship influences responses to corruption not only through instrumental calculations but also through expressive in-group loyalty. Strong group-serving biases in attributing responsibility for corruption have been widely documented, with partisanship and broader social identities – such as ethnicity, language, or religion – shaping how voters evaluate wrongdoing (Anduiza, Gallego, and Muñoz 2013; Solaz, De Vries, and De Geus 2019). Social identity theory suggests that group-based self-categorization fosters in-group loyalty, lowering voters' propensity to punish corrupt co-partisan or co-ethnic politicians (Solaz, De Vries, and De Geus 2019).

Empirically disentangling the impact of partisanship driven by expressive loyalty from that driven by instrumental motivations remains challenging. Voters may overlook in-group corruption not only out of affective ties, but also because they interpret shared identity as a cue for policy alignment, or anticipate preferential treatment or material benefits. Solaz, De Vries, and De Geus (2019), using laboratory experiments, isolate these mechanisms and demonstrate that in-group loyalty weakens accountability even in the absence of instrumental incentives – showing that expressive considerations alone can suffice to dampen electoral punishment for corruption. But such distinction of the channels through which partisanship affects corruption punishment is often impossible in more realistic survey settings.

When faced with corruption, voters may switch, abstain, or continue to support the incumbent. The feasibility of vote switching depends heavily on the availability of cred-

ible, untainted alternatives. When such options are lacking, voters are less able to hold corrupt politicians accountable (Schleiter and Voznaya 2014). Bågenholm and Charron (2015) further show that voters positioned at the ideological extremes – who perceive fewer parties as acceptable – are less likely to penalize corruption.[4] In the absence of credible alternatives, voters may respond to corruption by abstaining. Although smaller in scope, the literature on corruption and turnout consistently finds that corruption depresses participation, with evidence from Latin America (Chong et al. 2015), Eastern and Western Europe (Giommoni 2021), and large cross-national studies (Dahlberg and Solevid 2016). Finally, some voters may tolerate corruption and continue to support implicated politicians. Even when credible information is available and blame is correctly assigned, instrumental considerations or social identity ties may lead voters to weigh corruption against other perceived benefits.

Given the complex, overlapping trade-offs that shape electoral behavior, analyses must look beyond isolated causal mechanisms (De Vries and Solaz 2017). As De Vries and Solaz (2017, 396–397) note: *"The understanding of the different stages involved in the electoral punishment of corruption may account for the fact that some studies find that corruption takes a clear electoral toll on incumbents whereas others do not."* Building on their three-stage framework, we propose a small modification – illustrated in Figure 1 – that enhances the empirical testability of the theoretical model.

In De Vries and Solaz (2017)'s framework, the second stage – blame attribution – examines how responsibility is shaped by group-serving biases, while the third stage focuses on instrumental reasoning, when voters decide whether to continue supporting a corrupt incumbent. In practice, partisanship can shape both stages, influencing how voters assign blame and justify continued support.[5] To make the theoretical framework empirically

[4]Relatedly, widespread perceptions of corruption can foster cynicism, leading voters to prioritize competence or policy over integrity (Klašnja, Lupu, and Tucker 2021).

[5]Blame attribution is shaped not only by group-serving biases but also -— as De Vries and Solaz (2017)

testable, we propose treating these two dimensions – instrumental calculations and social group identities – as part of the second stage, which we term *mitigating conditions*.

While we acknowledge the distinct theoretical roles of instrumental reasoning and social identity in shaping corruption evaluations, it is empirically difficult to perfectly disentangle their effects (Solaz, De Vries, and De Geus 2019). Instrumental reasoning is often shaped by social group identity-based motives such as partisanship. Consequently, when estimating the effects of instrumental reasoning on corruption evaluations, we recognize that these assessments are likely influenced by social group identities as well. Conversely, when estimating the effect of social group identities (e.g. partisanship), the estimated effects may also capture instrumental considerations, as certain social segments might (rightly) expect material benefits from remaining loyal to particular parties. It is rarely possible to empirically isolate the distinct effect of group identity (e.g. partisanship) and instrumental calculations.[6] While this paper does not attempt to disentangle these mechanisms, by treating them within a single stage we emphasize that instrumental and identity-based considerations operate simultaneously and interactively.

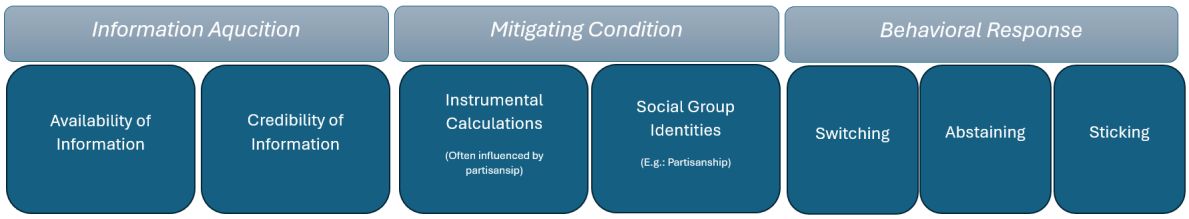

Figure 1: Theory of Corruption Voting based on De Vries and Solaz (2017) and Solaz, De Vries, and De Geus (2019)

note -— by the broader political context, including elite blame-shifting, media framing, and institutional complexity.

[6]In an excellent study, Solaz, De Vries, and De Geus (2019) use laboratory experiments to isolate these mechanisms and demonstrate that in-group loyalty weakens accountability even in the absence of instrumental incentives—showing that expressive considerations alone can suffice to dampen electoral punishment for corruption. To address the identification challenge noted above, however, they established in-groups based on participants' painter preferences.

3 The Hungarian Context

Hungary offers a compelling case for investigating the relationship between corruption perceptions and voting behavior, due to both the pervasive nature of corruption and the relatively limited electoral consequences faced by corrupt actors. According to Transparency International, Hungary is now ranked as the most corrupt country in Europe (Transparency 2024), reflecting a broader decline over the past decade: in 2012, it ranked 46th globally with a Corruption Perceptions Index (CPI) score of 55; by 2024, its score had dropped to 41, placing it 82nd out of 180 countries. Public perceptions align with expert assessments of governance decline: the 2024 Eurobarometer reports that 88% of Hungarians view corruption as widespread – compared to 68% across the EU – and 51% believe that corruption has increased over the past three years (Eurobarometer 2024).

Despite this, mounting evidence suggests that politicians of both governing and opposition parties, who have been widely accused or even formally charged with corruption, often face little to no meaningful electoral sanction. Two recent cases from Hungary's 2024 local elections exemplify this pattern. In Budapest's 3rd district, László Kiss – the joint opposition candidate representing DK, Momentum, MSZP, Párbeszéd, LMP, and Jobbik – was re-elected mayor with 47.1% of the vote (representing 30.3% of eligible voters), despite longstanding corruption allegations. Kiss is suspected of arranging municipal contracts with a company owned by a close associate, through which he and other local officials allegedly received kickbacks. These bribes were reportedly concealed through inflated or fictitious contracts (Dezső 2024).

A similar pattern is evident in the case of György Simonka, a Fidesz–KDNP politician and former Member of Parliament. Despite standing trial since 2019 for large-scale budgetary fraud committed as part of an alleged criminal organization – with prosecutors seeking an eight-and-a-half-year prison sentence and asset confiscation (Bod 2024)

–, Simonka was elected mayor of Pusztaottlaka with 69.0% of the vote (42.0% of eligible voters). These examples are not isolated. In the 2024 local elections, several candidates facing corruption allegations, criminal charges, or even prior convictions sought and, in many cases, retained public office.[7]

Beyond the prevalence of corruption, Hungary's institutional and political context – characterized by an uneven media landscape, concerns over judicial independence, extensive pre-electoral welfare transfers, and pervasive partisanship shaping citizens' perceptions across a wide range of issues – further challenges the mechanisms through which voters might sanction corruption. Since Fidesz–KDNP's electoral victory and subsequent attainment of a constitutional supermajority in 2010, the media landscape has undergone a profound transformation, marked by increasing consolidation and the growing dominance of pro-government outlets.[8] Over the past decade, government-affiliated actors have expanded control through acquisitions, the capture of public broadcasting, and smear campaigns against critical journalists (Reuters 2019).[9] Selective allocation of state advertising and subsidies further entrenches this dominance, with pro-government outlets benefiting from public funding while independent media face financial strain and political pressure. These economic levers, combined with regulatory and legal measures, have produced what observers describe as a "captured media environment," where political elites control the flow of information and weaken democratic accountability (Szeidl and Szucs 2021). This approach aligns with the rationale articulated by Balázs Orbán, the Prime Minister's political director: "whoever controls a country's media controls the country's thinking – and thus, the country itself" (HVG 2023).

While people typically learn about corruption allegations from the media, court rul-

[7]See further details in Kozák (2024).

[8]A growing body of research identifies media capture as a driver of Hungary's democratic backsliding, emphasizing how state-aligned media amplify government narratives while systematically discrediting the political opposition (Haggard and Kaufman 2021; Kelemen 2021).

[9]See more details in Appendix A.

ings – even when reported by the media – lend formal legal weight that enhances the credibility and impact of such accusations. In Hungary, however, the judiciary is also politicized to varying degrees: while some institutions retain relative independence, others are more vulnerable to political influence. Crucially, the very existence of a ruling depends on whether charges are filed. The Prosecutor's Office, which is widely regarded as politicized in politically sensitive cases, has had exclusive authority over indictments since the abolition of subsidiary (private) prosecution, a mechanism that provides alternative channels for judicial review in other systems. Between 2010 and 2025, the office was led by a former Fidesz party member and parliamentary candidate with close personal ties to the Prime Minister. As a result, substantial evidence indicates that opposition politicians are significantly more likely to face indictment in corruption-related cases.[10]

Beyond media consolidation and institutional control of the judiciary, the Fidesz government has, over the past decade, introduced a wide array of welfare-enhancing subsidies targeted at specific social groups. Scholars have argued that these policies have played a crucial role in sustaining the government's electoral success (Szabó and Reiff 2025; Pepinsky, Reiff, and Szabó 2025) – potentially offsetting concerns such as corruption scandals. Key measures include the reintroduction of the thirteenth-month pension, large-scale tax refunds, the Childbearing Loan, a government-backed, interest-free loan and an extensive system of housing subsidies. The latter encompasses subsidized credit for first-time homebuyers, the Family Housing Allowance Program (CSOK) for married couples, its rural variant (Falusi CSOK), and the Home Renovation Subsidy. By maintaining or expanding these benefits even in times of economic hardship, the government may promote greater voter tolerance of its misconduct, including accusations of corruption. These instruments and strategies are crucial because, although Hungary is often described as a

[10]Even when indictments are brought against Fidesz-affiliated politicians, these proceedings tend to be selective, slow-moving, and often symbolic. Trials are frequently subject to lengthy delays -— sometimes extending over a decade —- while Fidesz-aligned defendants typically avoid pre-trial detention.

case of democratic backsliding or a competitive authoritarian regime, both frameworks underscore the continued importance of elections. Securing electoral support from citizens remains central to the regime's stability and legitimacy.

In parallel with these developments, and partly as a consequence of them, partisanship has become one of the most salient social identities in Hungary, dividing society not only during elections but also across major public issues. Ideological polarization, reflected in growing distance between voters on substantive matters – such as policy evaluation, perceptions of corruption, tolerance of democratic backsliding, and attitudes toward immigration – has become a defining feature of Hungarian society.

4 Data and Research Design

To examine when Hungarian voters fail to sanction corruption, we conducted an original survey experiment in April–May 2024, preceding the concurrent local and European Parliamentary elections in June 2024.[11] Data were collected through face-to-face interviews with a nationally representative sample of 1,062 respondents.

We employed a conjoint experimental design to estimate the causal effects of multiple candidate attributes on vote choice.[12] Each participant evaluated five pairs of hypothetical candidates, resulting in assessments of ten candidate profiles per respondent and a total of 10,620 candidate-level observations. Candidate profiles were randomized along seven attributes selected for their relevance to real-world voting behavior. Table 1 presents the full set of attributes that we considered in the generation of candidate profiles (for further details, see Appendix B).

[11]The survey, conducted with the Hungarian firm TÁRKI, is representative of Hungarian voters by gender, age, settlement type, and education.

[12]By embedding sensitive items – such as tolerance for corruption – among randomly varying attributes, conjoint experiments mitigate social desirability bias (Horiuchi, Markovich, and Yamamoto 2022) and approximate real-world voting behavior with high external validity.

Attribute	Levels
Gender	Male Female
Experience	Has been mayor, decreased local unemployment Has been mayor, failed to decrease local unemployment Has never been mayor
Supporting Party	Fidesz Left-wing opposition Independent / Mi Hazánk
Information on Religiosity	Atheist Not known Christian, attends services on major occasions Christian, regularly attends services
Corrupt?	Yes, like many other local politicians Yes, unlike many other local politicians No
Source of Corruption Information	Sentenced by court RTL Klub news program telex.hu M1 news program origo.hu
Corruption Type and Side Benefits	Sold land to friend, 10M HUF below market price; private house built Sold land to friend, 10M HUF below market price; factory with 120 jobs Sold land to friend, 100M HUF below market price; private house built Sold land to friend, 100M HUF below market price; factory with 120 jobs Accepted a bribe of 10M HUF

Table 1: Attributes and Levels Used in the Conjoint Experiment

Following each conjoint task, respondents answered questions that captured their preferences, including a forced-choice between the two hypothetical candidates. Importantly, the choice task included a third option "I would not vote" to better reflect real-world elections and assess whether respondents abstain or still vote when both candidates are tainted by corruption (Agerberg 2020).

To enhance realism and external validity (Hainmueller, Hopkins, and Yamamoto 2014), we designed the marginal distributions of candidate attributes to reflect the characteristics

of likely candidates in the 2024 local and European Parliamentary elections. We used weighted randomization so that some attribute values appeared more frequently (e.g., male candidates were more common, reflecting the gender distribution in Hungarian politics).

We also employed restricted randomization to prevent unrealistic or illogical attribute combinations. For instance, the two candidates in each pair could not be affiliated with the same political party, and a corruption allegation involving a Fidesz politician could not originate from government-aligned media, preserving plausibility within Hungary's media landscape. However, we did not restrict the randomization of information sources by respondents' party affiliation. As Mérték (2023) shows, many individuals – regardless of partisanship – consume diverse media sources despite Fidesz's extensive media control. The main partisan divide lies not in media exposure but in perceived credibility.

In addition to randomizing attribute values, we randomized attribute order at the respondent level to control for order effects (Hainmueller, Hopkins, and Yamamoto 2014). The three corruption-related attributes were consistently grouped together to enhance clarity and ensure comparability across profiles.

5 Results

We begin with the results of the baseline conjoint experiment, summarized in Figure 2.[13] In this initial specification, we isolate the effect of corruption by comparing "clean" and "corrupt" candidates, without accounting for specific features of the corruption case.

We find that involvement in a corruption case substantially decreases a candidate's likelihood of being selected: the estimated effect is a 23.2–percentage-point reduction,

[13]In this and all subsequent figures, the reference categories are male candidates with no prior political experience, no party affiliation (independents), no information on religiosity, and no involvement in corruption.

highly statistically significant.[14]

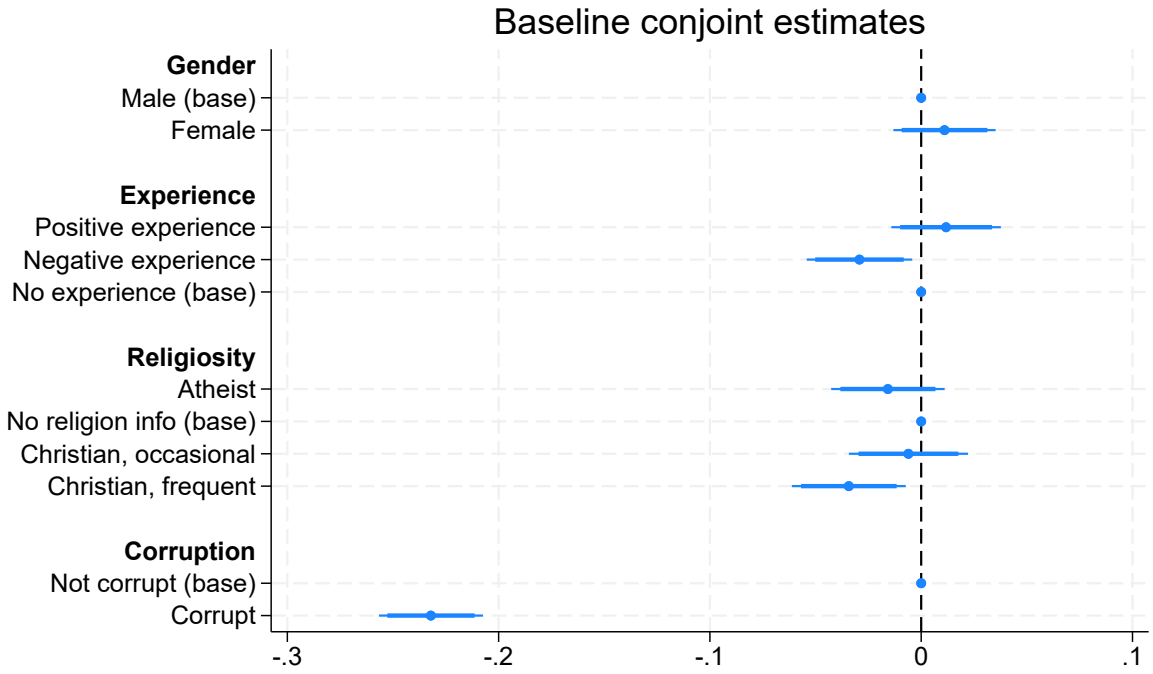

Figure 2: The Effect of Candidate Attributes on Selection Probability

As shown in Figure 2, candidate gender has a modest, statistically insignificant effect: female candidates are 1.1 percentage points more likely to be selected than males. Candidates with positive experience – reducing local unemployment – are 1.2 points more likely to be chosen than those without prior experience, although the difference is not statistically significant. In contrast, negative experience – defined as having failed to reduce unemployment – reduces selection probability by 2.9 points, a modest but significant effect ($p = 0.022$).

Preferences regarding religiosity are more nuanced. Relative to candidates with unspecified religiosity, self-identified atheists or Christians who occasionally attend services are slightly less likely to be chosen (by 1.6 and 0.6 points, respectively), though these dif-

[14] Additional analysis (Figure A1, Appendix C) distinguishes between corruption perceived as widespread and that attributed to a specific candidate. The estimated effects (−23.3 and −23.1 percentage points, respectively) are statistically indistinguishable.

ferences are not significant. Regular church attendance, however, decreases the selection probability by 3.4 points – a statistically significant effect ($p = 0.013$).

Party affiliation emerges as one of the strongest predictors of candidate selection. Although omitted from Figure 2 for presentation clarity, full results are available in Figure A2 in Appendix C. Support from the respondent's preferred party increases a candidate's probability of selection by between 51.6 and 64.8 percentage points, underscoring the centrality of partisanship in shaping electoral preferences.

5.1 Information

We designed the experiment to ensure the availability of information about corruption; nonetheless, we varied whether the candidate was implicated in corruption. For candidates involved in corruption, we randomized the source of this information. To contextualize this intervention and assess the broader information environment, we also collected data on respondents' media consumption habits.[15] We find that 41% of voters gather information on domestic politics daily, and another 18% do so regularly, though not every day. The remaining 41% report low engagement with domestic political information, indicating that a substantial share of the population is not regularly exposed to political news — a pattern also observed by Ares, Breitenstein, and Hernández (2024) in Spain. Appendix D.1 sheds light on partisan media consumption, showing that despite the tendency of Fidesz voters to rely on pro-government sources and opposition voters on independent media, a notable share of the population remains exposed to politically diverse content.[16] This suggests that media consumption in Hungary is not entirely confined to partisan information bubbles. It also supports the validity of our experimental design, where exposure

[15]Respondents reported how frequently they accessed each of 26 major Hungarian media outlets – television, radio, print, and online – to obtain information about domestic politics. The outlets appear in Table A1 of Appendix D.1.

[16]Figure A5 shows media consumption patterns, highlighting partisan variation in exposure to pro-government and independent outlets.

to corruption-related information was randomized independently of party affiliation.

Nonetheless, simply providing information does not necessarily enhance electoral accountability; the quality, and particularly *the credibility of the source*, is crucial. In our experiment, we included four prominent media outlets: two television channels (M1 and RTL) and two online news portals (origo.hu and telex.hu). Among these, M1 and origo.hu are Fidesz-controlled, while RTL and telex.hu operate independently of government influence.

Figure 3 presents respondents' evaluations of the credibility of these four media outlets, measured on a 0–10 scale.[17] As one information source in the experiment was a court ruling, we additionally asked respondents to rate their trust in the independence of Hungarian courts on the same 0–10 scale.

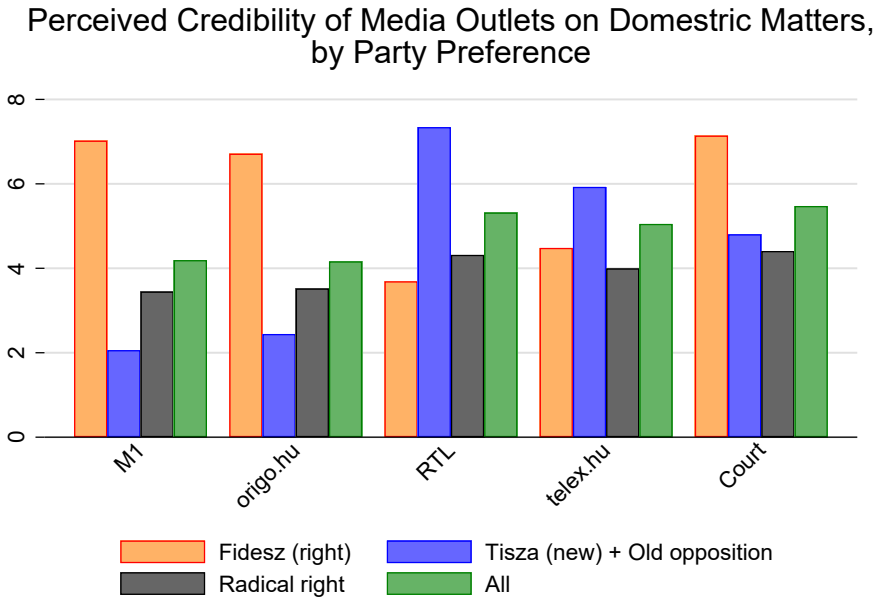

Figure 3: Perceived Credibility of Media Outlets by Party Preference

The results reveal a pronounced partisan divide, highlighting the deep polarization of

[17]Respondents were asked: "To what extent do you think that the following media outlets provide credible information on domestic politics?" (0 = not at all credible; 10 = fully credible.)

media credibility perceptions and judicial trust along partisan lines in Hungary. Fidesz voters rate the Fidesz-controlled M1 and origo.hu as highly credible (around 7 on average), while assigning substantially lower credibility scores (below 5) to the independent outlets RTL and telex.hu. This pattern is reversed among opposition voters, including supporters of the newly founded Tisza party and the left coalition, with RTL and telex.hu viewed as far more credible. The magnitude of this divide is striking: M1, for example, averages about 7 among Fidesz voters but just over 2 among opposition voters.

A similar partisan divide emerges in perceptions of judicial independence: Fidesz voters report high trust (7.1), Tisza voters express low trust (4.1), and left-coalition voters moderate trust (5.5). Nonetheless, average trust in the judiciary remains somewhat higher than perceptions of media credibility across all voter groups, suggesting that courts are still viewed as a more neutral or legitimate institution.

To assess public awareness of media partisan bias, we also asked respondents to rate the perceived balancedness of various media outlets on a 0–10 scale.[18] As Figure A8 in Appendix D.2 shows, respondents across party lines are broadly aware of which outlets are pro-government, balanced, or government-critical.This suggests that while partisans differ sharply in the credibility they attribute to news sources, they nonetheless share relatively accurate perceptions of those sources' political orientation.

Next we examine how source credibility shapes voters' responses to information about candidate corruption. To measure the credibility effect, we adopt a credibility-from-affinity framework (Lupia and McCubbins 1998), which defines credibility in terms of the perceived relationship between the information source and the individual. While much of the literature conceptualizes credibility in terms of source incentives – whether the source has an incentive to lie (Weitz-Shapiro and Winters 2017) –, the affinity-based approach is better suited to our context: it captures heterogeneity in voters' willingness

[18] 0 indicates entirely government-critical, 10 entirely pro-government, and 5 fully balanced.

to trust information in highly polarized settings like Hungary and avoids assuming that respondents can accurately assess a source's incentive structure.

Figure 4 begins by presenting the baseline effect of corruption on vote choice (-23.2 percentage points), which is then disaggregated by the credibility of the information source in the second panel.[19] The estimates indicate that the probability of voting for corrupt candidates decreases by 20.8 percentage points when the information is provided by a non-credible source. When the source is fully credible, the decline in voting probability increases slightly to 24.5 percentage points. However, the difference between these two estimates is not statistically significant ($p = 0.16$).

Finally we analyze heterogeneity in the source credibility effect across voter subgroups, drawing on theoretical expectations from Winters and Weitz-Shapiro (2020) and Botero et al. (2015). The third and fourth panels of Figure 4 show that source credibility has a significant effect among respondents who identify as core voters or report high levels of political interest – reflecting greater critical engagement with political information.[20] By contrast, we find no evidence that the credibility effect varies by frequency of media consumption.[21]

[19] All disaggregations are implemented by adding interaction terms in our regressions.
[20] Detailed estimates are provided on Figure A9, Appendix D.3.
[21] See Figures A10 and A11 in Appendix D.3).

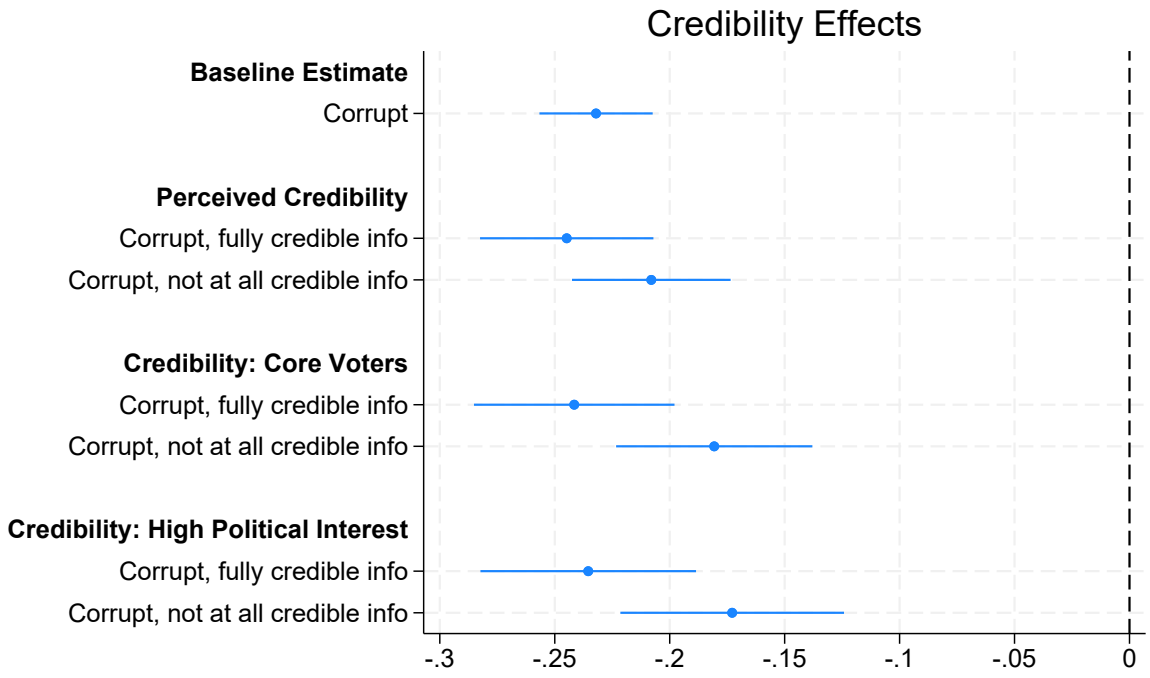

Figure 4: The Role of Information Credibility in Voter Responses to Corruption

5.2 Mitigating Conditions

This section probes the mitigating factors and shows how social group identities and instrumental calculations might overwrite corruption punishment.

5.2.1 Social Group Identity

We focus on two particular dimensions of social group identity that are especially relevant in the Hungarian context – partisanship and religiosity – to examine how they influence electoral accountability for corruption (Pepinsky, Reiff, and Szabó 2024). Our primary focus is on partisan identity, which we operationalize through the concept of party match: instances in which a respondent's self-declared party preference corresponds with the party affiliation of a hypothetical candidate.

The baseline effects panel in Figure 5 shows that when there is a match between the

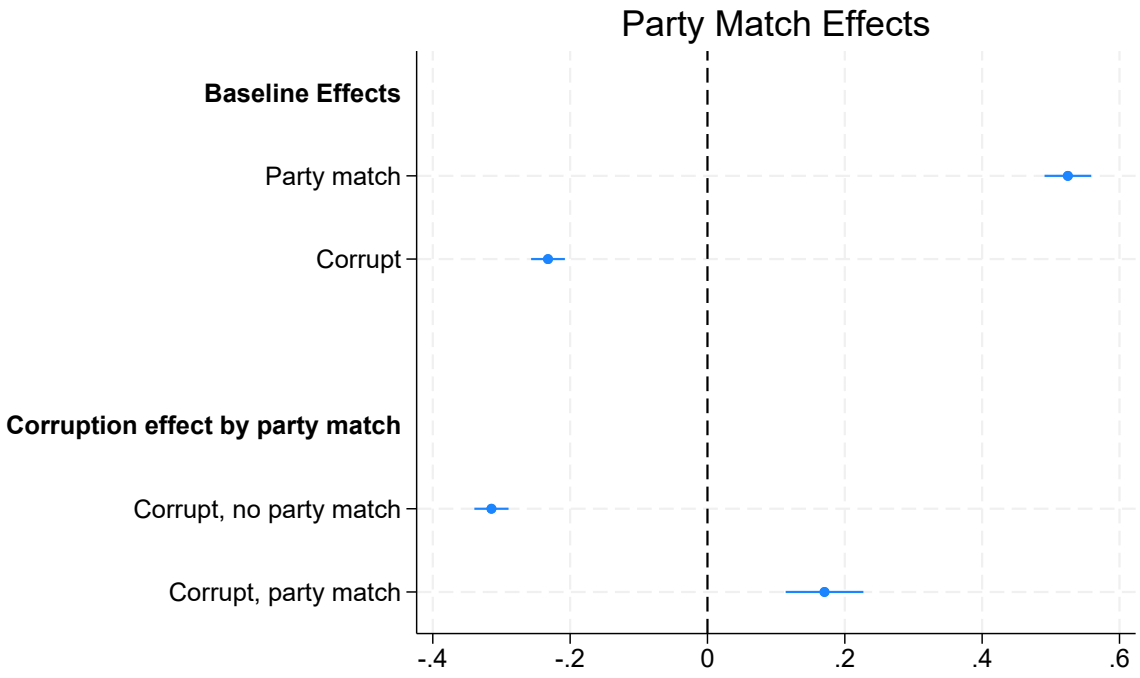

Figure 5: Corruption Punishment With and Without Party Match

respondent's preferred party and the party supporting the candidate, the probability of voting for that candidate is 52.5 percentage points larger when there is no such party match (78.7% versus 26.2%, respectively).[22] In contrast, candidates involved in corruption are, on average, punished by a 23.2 percentage point decrease in vote likelihood (23.3% for corrupt versus 46.6% for clean candidates). The second panel disaggregates this corruption effect by party match and reveals that when the corrupt candidate is affiliated with the respondent's preferred party, there is no evidence of electoral sanctioning. Conversely, co-partisan corrupt candidates are significantly more likely to be selected (63.6%) than average non-corrupt candidates with randomly assigned attributes (46.6%). Partisan alignment increases vote choice for corrupt candidates by 17.0 percentage points, a highly significant effect.[23] Compared to the estimated effect of party match for candidates with

[22]Absolute vote choice probabilities are reported from marginal means estimations (see Figure A12 in Appendix E.1).

[23]This effect is large and statistically significant across partisan groups: +15.7 points for Fidesz supporters,

random attributes (+52.5 percentage points), corruption markedly reduces this effect (to only +17.0 percentage points).[24] Importantly, the effect of partisanship on voting for corrupt candidates may partly reflect its broader evaluative function – as a running tally of party performance, encompassing perceptions of economic outcomes, policy proximity, and value alignment. By contrast, in cases of no party match, respondents impose more severe sanctions: the vote probability for corrupt candidates drops by 31.5 percentage points (15.1%) relative to non-corrupt counterparts (46.6%) – an effect that notably exceeds the average punishment of 23.2 percentage points estimated in the baseline model.

We next examine the effect of religiosity match – defined as shared religious or non-religious identity between respondents and candidate – on electoral accountability for corruption. As shown on Figure A14 in Appendix E.1, religious respondents are not more tolerant of corruption by religious candidates; their evaluations mirror the overall average. This suggests that, unlike partisanship, shared religious identity does not mitigate electoral sanctioning for corruption.

5.2.2 Instrumental Calculations

We next assess how citizens implicitly weigh corrupt behavior against perceived benefits, focusing on the mitigating effect of side benefits, defined as job creation through the construction of a new factory. Two of the five corruption scenarios in the conjoint experiment include such benefits. To vary the perceived severity of corruption, we also randomize the size of the corrupt deal—10 or 100 million forints (approximately 25,000 or 250,000 USD) (see Table 1, Section 4).

+20.3 for left-coalition voters, and +36.7 for radical-right voters, with no statistically significant differences between them.

[24] We also find that the effect of party match on corruption tolerance varies by political interest. As shown in Figure A13 (Appendix E.1), politically interested respondents are 21.0 percentage points more likely to support a corrupt co-partisan, compared to an average candidate, while the corresponding effect among less interested voters is only 12.3 points—a statistically significant difference.

We begin with descriptive evidence showing that respondents correctly ranked the corruption scenarios by perceived seriousness (Figure A15, Appendix E.2). The case involving job creation and a relatively small misuse of public funds was rated as the least serious.[25] Importantly, even when large sums were involved, corruption cases tied to job creation were perceived as less serious on average.[26]

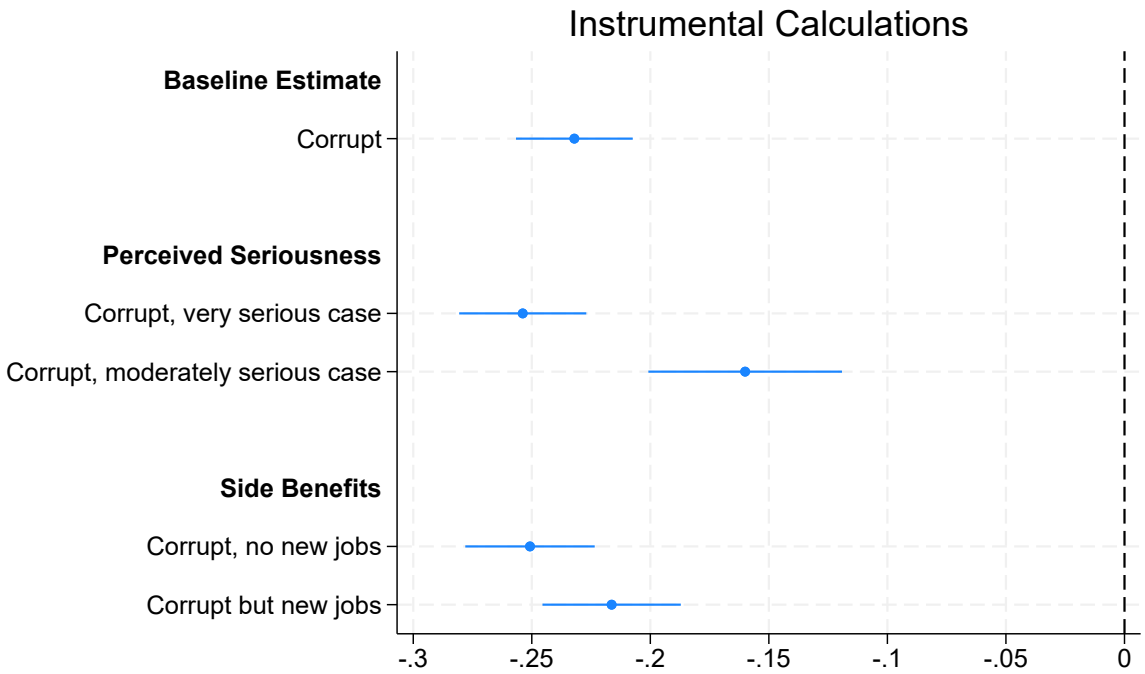

Figure 6: Instrumental Calculations in Voter Responses to Corruption

We next examine the extent to which voters' views on the seriousness of corruption, as well as their broader instrumental calculations, shape their responses to corruption. The first row of Figure 6 presents the baseline conjoint estimate for being corrupt (-23.2 p.p.). The subsequent panels disaggregate this result by perceived seriousness and the

[25]Before the conjoint tasks, respondents rated each corruption case on a 0–10 scale, from "not at all serious" (0) to "very serious" (10).

[26]Understanding perceptions of corruption severity is crucial in Hungary, where the ruling party often frames dubious practices as serving the national interest. Since 2010, Fidesz has justified such actions as building a "national capitalist class" (Botos 2015). Consistent with this narrative, Fidesz supporters rate corruption cases slightly less serious than others, though not significantly so, while still correctly ranking them by severity.

presence of side benefits. The second panel shows that when corruption is perceived as "very serious," support for the corrupt candidate drops by 25.4 percentage points relative to a non-corrupt one; when it is viewed as "moderately serious" (5 on the 0–10 scale), the decrease is 16.0 points.

While the second panel of Figure 6 shows that voters take into account their perceived seriousness in general, the third panel illustrates that side benefits to voters (one particular element that decreases perceived seriousness) indeed help corrupt politicians in reducing electoral sanction. When corruption is paired with tangible benefits for the community (job creation), voters impose significantly lighter sanctions. Specifically, the vote share for corrupt candidates declines by 21.6 percentage points in such cases, compared to 25.1 points in cases without compensatory benefits – a statistically significant difference.

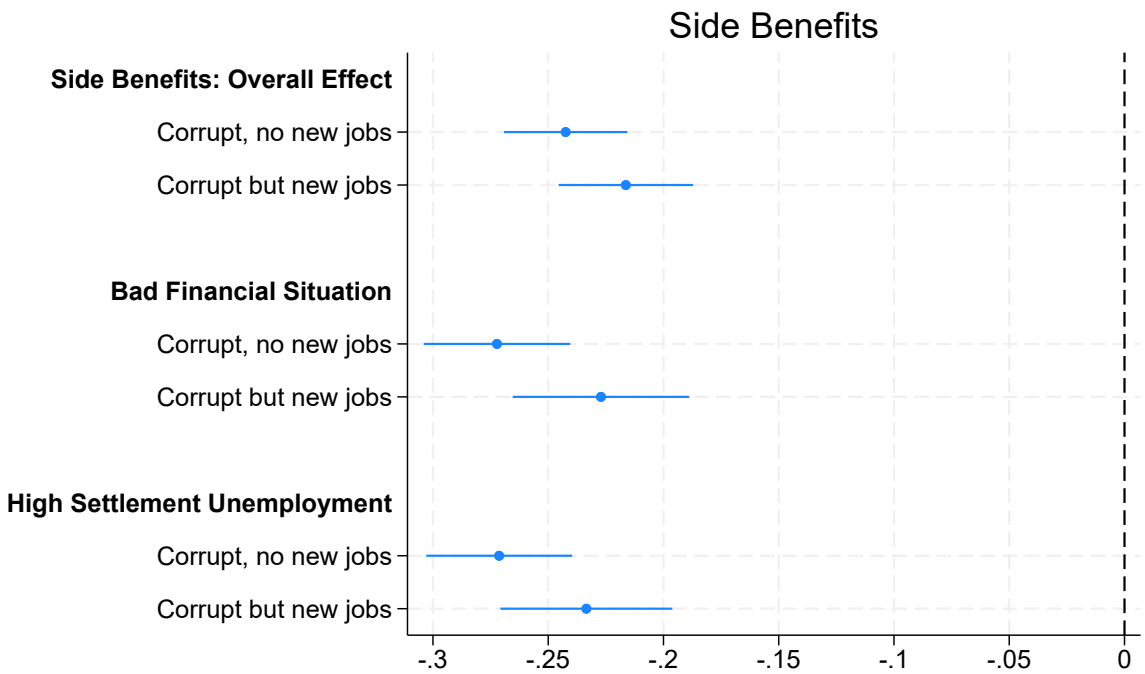

Figure 7: Instrumental Calculations in Voter Responses to Corruption – Heterogeneous Voter Responses to Corruption with Side Benefits

Finally, we explore the heterogeneity behind the result on side benefits (in panel 3 of

Figure 6, repeated in the top panel of Figure 7 as a benchmark). We leverage a unique dataset linking individual survey responses with administrative data at the settlement level – the smallest administrative unit in Hungary. This linkage captures respondents' actual local economic context and, by using objective unemployment data, mitigates common limitations of survey-based measures such as social desirability bias in self-reported employment and attenuation bias in perceived local conditions. The middle and bottom panels of Figure 7 show that respondents in financially precarious conditions and those residing in high-unemployment areas are especially likely to punish corruption when it is not accompanied by tangible economic benefits. In the absence of such compensatory gains, they sanction it more severely, yielding statistically significant differences between their responses to corruption with and without side benefits.

5.3 Behavioral Responses

Thus far, we have focused solely on the changing likelihood of supporting corrupt politicians, which risks obscuring key mechanisms: declines in support may reflect either abstention or shifts in party preference. This distinction is crucial for understanding the electoral consequences of corruption, as demobilization and political realignment carry different implications for democratic accountability. To capture these dynamics more precisely, we next disaggregate respondents' reactions into three categories: party loyalty, vote switching, and abstention.

We restrict our analysis to profiles where the candidate is supported by the respondent's preferred party – referred to as party match cases. The restricted sample consists of $N = 1,821$ such hypothetical candidates, out of 10,620 profiles in the dataset. Importantly, in addition to the randomly assigned attributes of the in-party candidate, we also include the randomly assigned attributes of the opponent candidate as explanatory variables. By design – replicating real-world electoral contexts –, opponent candidates are never

affiliated with the same party as the focal candidate.

We begin by observing that on average, the probability that respondents support a candidate endorsed by their preferred party is 78.8% (top row of Figure 8).[27] To understand why this share is not closer to 100%, we test which attributes predict in-party voting ("sticking"), and find that only the two candidates' corruption indicators are statistically significant (Figure A16 in Appendix F.1). This suggests that corruption matters to voters even when the candidate represents their preferred party – but the key question is to what extent.

The top panel of Figure 8 presents the estimated effect of in-party candidate corruption on voter loyalty in the party-match sub-sample. When the in-party candidate is corrupt, the probability of sticking decreases to 63.5% (by 30.1 percentage points compared to the 93.6% when that candidate is not corrupt). Nevertheless, the probability of supporting a corrupt in-party candidate remains substantively large, indicating a persistent partisan loyalty even in the presence of corruption.

We further investigate how this decrease in support probability for a corrupt in-party candidate is conditioned by the corruptness of the opponent candidate. This analysis tests the proposition that voters are more likely to tolerate corruption within their preferred party when viable, clean alternatives are lacking (Klašnja, Lupu, and Tucker 2021). The second panel of Figure 8 shows that when the opponent candidate is also corrupt, the negative effect of in-party corruption on support attenuates: the probability of supporting the in-party candidate decreases to only 69.8%, compared to 57.4% when the opponent is clean. This suggests that partisan loyalty is more resilient when the alternative is similarly tainted. Yet it is striking that even when a clean alternative exists, the probability of supporting the corrupt in-party candidate remains high, at nearly 60%.[28]

[27] To illustrate the absolute magnitude of political support, we report vote choice probabilities derived from marginal means estimations.

[28] As none of the other candidate's attributes (gender, religiosity, political experience) have significant

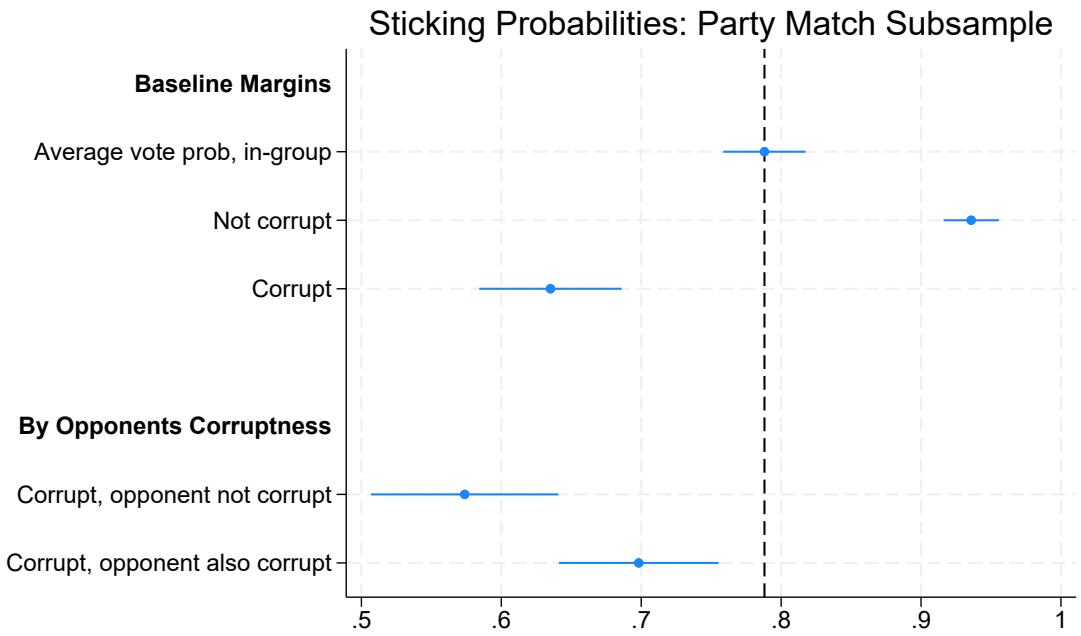

Figure 8: Behavioral Responses to Corruption: Likelihood of Supporting a Corrupt Candidate from the Preferred Political Party (Marginal Mean Estimations)

A decline in support for a corrupt candidate affiliated with a respondent's preferred political party can reflect two distinct behavioral responses: abstaining from voting or switching support to an alternative party's candidate. Figure 9 disaggregates the observed 30.1 percentage point decrease in support for a corrupt in-party candidate into these two response types. On average, when the preferred party's candidate is corrupt, 18.2 percentage points of the decline in support is attributable to abstention, while 11.9 percentage points reflect switching to another candidate, indicating that many voters respond to in-party corruption by withdrawing from participation rather than defecting—thereby limiting the electoral punishment of corruption.[29]

effects on sticking, abstention, or switching, we do not discuss them.

[29]We decompose these effects by estimating three regressions on the sub-sample of in-party candidates, each using random candidate attributes. The first ("sticking") models voting for the in-party candidate (Figure 8); the second ("abstaining") models abstention (voting for neither candidate); and the third ("switching") models voting for the opponent. The coefficients on the "in-party candidate being corrupt" variable across these regressions form the basis of the decomposition.

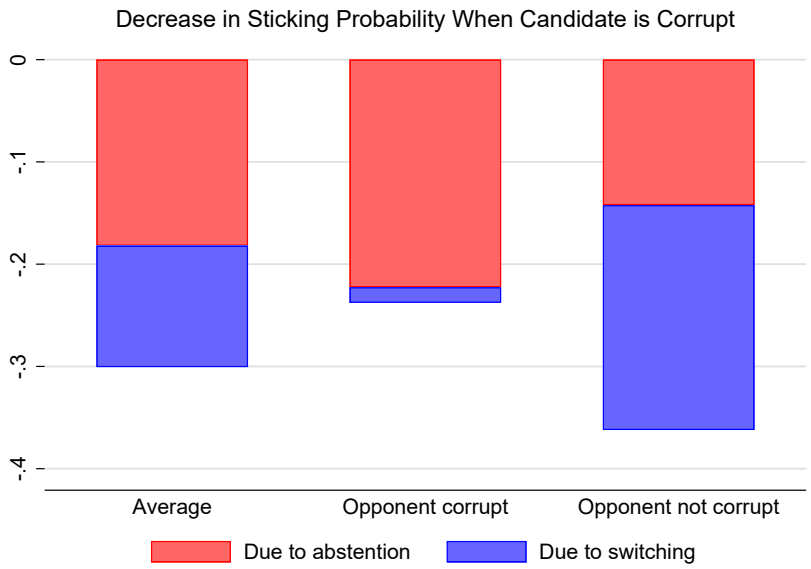

Figure 9: Decomposition of Decreased Support for a Corrupt In-Party Candidate: Abstention versus Switching

These responses further vary depending on whether the opponent candidate is also corrupt. When both candidates are corrupt, support for the preferred party's candidate declines by 22.3 percentage points, which is almost entirely driven by abstention. In contrast, when the opponent is not corrupt, the decline in support increases to 36.2 percentage points, with 14.2 percentage points explained by abstaining, and the remaining 22.0 by switching to the clean opponent. This pattern is concerning, as it suggests that corruption often fails to outweigh partisan animosity toward the opposition: even when a clean alternative exists, many voters either continue to support the corrupt candidate or abstain.

5.3.1 Abstaining

To complement our analysis of behavioral responses to corruption, we now examine the determinants of *abstention* using a collapsed dataset in which the unit of observation is

candidate pairs rather than individual candidates. [30]

In this collapsed dataset, our main explanatory variables capture candidate pair characteristics, including the number of female candidates; a dummy of both candidates having negative track records; party and religiosity/atheism matches between candidates and respondents; and most importantly, the number of corrupt candidates. We hypothesize that the likelihood of abstention increases as the number of corrupt candidates increases.[31]

Figure 10 confirms that corruption significantly increases abstention. When one candidate is corrupt, the probability of abstention increases by 5.0 percentage points ($p = 0.002$); when both are corrupt, abstention increases by 26.4 percentage points ($p = 0$). Given the 29.9% baseline abstention rate, we conclude that the vast majority of abstentions occur in situations where both candidates are corrupt.

The other explanatory variables are insignificant, with the notable exception of party match. When one candidate is affiliated with the respondent's preferred party, the probability of abstention decreases sharply by 28.7 percentage points. This effect is comparable in magnitude to that of the "both candidates are corrupt" condition, underscoring the strong influence of partisanship on voting behavior.[32]

Finally, we examine respondent-level predictors of abstention (Figure A18, Appendix F.2). Interestingly, left-leaning respondents (scores 0–3 on the 0–10 left-right ideological scale) are 14.8 percentage points less likely to abstain compared to centrists. Religious respondents are also less likely to abstain, possibly reflecting a stronger sense of civic duty to participate (–4.8 percentage points, $p = 0.099$). Politically interested individuals (–6.1 per-

[30] Respondents abstained in 29.9% of hypothetical candidate pairs, providing sufficient variation for a linear probability model with abstention as the dependent variable.

[31] We do not distinguish between "corrupt like many others" and "corrupt unlike most others." Figure A17 in Appendix F.2 confirms that this does not materially affect our findings.

[32] We find that the number of female candidates has no significant effect on abstention. When both candidates are incompetent (i.e., have negative track records), abstention increases by 3.0 percentage points; however, this effect is not statistically significant ($p = 0.371$). Religiosity match reduces abstention by 3.0 points (not statistically significant, $p = 0.113$), while shared atheism has no effect ($p = 0.220$).

centage points) and those with lower corruption perceptions (–4.4 percentage points) are likewise less likely to abstain, although these estimates do not reach statistical significance at the 10% level.

Taken together, these findings indicate that candidate corruption substantially increases the likelihood of abstention, whereas party match markedly reduces it. Although certain respondent-level characteristics also affect abstention, the estimated effect sizes are much smaller.

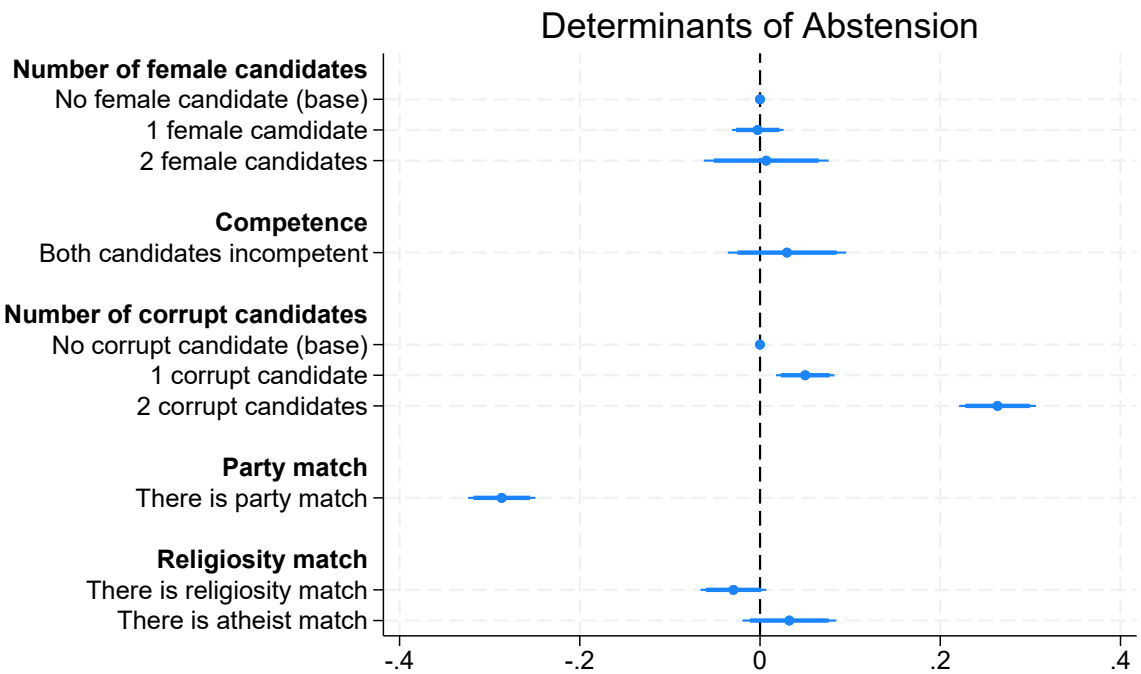

Figure 10: Determinants of Abstention

6 Conclusion

Elections are often regarded as the primary mechanism through which citizens can hold corrupt politicians accountable. Yet voters frequently fail to punish corrupt actors, a puzzle that prior research has variously explained with reference to institutional design, the availability and credibility of information, economic considerations, and group-serving biases. Most of these factors, however, have been examined in isolation, even though electoral choices in practice involve weighing multiple, intersecting trade-offs, and the relative importance of any single factor is likely to vary across individuals. As De Vries and Solaz (2017) argue, the electoral consequences of corruption unfold across three stages—information acquisition, blame attribution, and behavioral response—yet this framework has rarely been subjected to systematic empirical testing. In particular, few studies disaggregate the underlying behavioral mechanisms and assess the conditions under which voters remain loyal to a corrupt co-partisan, defect to an alternative, or abstain altogether.

Our study has sought to address existing gaps by examining all three stages of corruption voting and by disaggregating voters' behavioral responses. Using a conjoint experiment in Hungary, we identified four core findings. First, corruption assessments are strongly conditioned by the credibility of the information source among committed partisans and politically attentive voters. Second, although corruption reduces support for co-partisan candidates, the reduction is limited: partisan loyalty substantially shields them from serious electoral sanction, and corrupt co-partisan candidates remain more popular than the average non-corrupt candidate. Third, voters in economically precarious circumstances and those in high-unemployment areas are more inclined to punish corruption when it fails to yield tangible community benefits, such as job creation. Finally, declines in support for corrupt co-partisans manifest primarily through abstention

rather than switching: while switching only occurs when the opposing candidate is clean, abstention also remains a common form of punishment even in such cases.

There are at least three important implications of our results. First, they underscore the importance of accounting for multiple mitigating factors simultaneously when evaluating the electoral consequences of corruption. Moreover, the influence of these factors varies systematically across social groups, highlighting the need not only to identify such mechanisms but also to understand which segments of the electorate are most responsive to them. Second, our findings on behavioral responses—particularly abstention, including in the face of a corrupt in-group but clean opposition candidate—carry significant implications for accountability. Corruption emerges as one of the key drivers of abstention, reflecting disillusionment and apathy that reduce participation in core democratic processes and signal that corruption entails limited political costs, thereby fostering undemocratic dynamics. More troubling, however, is the prevalence of abstention when voters are confronted with a clean but ideologically distant opposition candidate, which reveals the overwhelming strength of partisanship: voters refrain from crossing partisan lines regardless of integrity. Both patterns are normatively concerning, as they suggest that when voters abstain rather than switch, the electoral costs of corruption remain limited, thereby weakening politicians' incentives to avoid corrupt practices. Finally, our finding that partisan loyalty is central to the absence of strong punishment for corruption reflects broader state–society dynamics in Hungary (Pepinsky 2025). Accordingly, partisanship in contemporary Hungary functions not merely as an important cleavage but as a marker of belonging to morally and historically grounded communities whose proper relation to the state—and to political parties now closely fused with it—is defined by integration and duty. Voters' acceptance of corruption thus appears less a failure of democratic accountability than an expression of allegiance to a partisan vision that prioritizes membership in a single, morally unified national community—even at the cost of

overlooking transgressive behavior.

Our analysis also suggests several directions for future research. First, more empirical work is needed to test the three-stage model in contexts where mitigating factors such as partisanship or media credibility are less salient – for instance, where media are less polarized, partisan attachments weaker, or social identities such as ethnicity or religion stronger. Second, future studies should examine how local socio-economic conditions beyond settlement-level unemployment shape tolerance for unethical behavior, particularly when it yields visible community benefits. Finally, research should further investigate the behavioral mechanisms of corruption voting and identify, across different institutional contexts and levels of party competition, the conditions under which citizens remain loyal to a corrupt co-partisan, switch to an alternative, or abstain.

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When Do Voters Punish Corrupt Candidates? Evidence from Hungary

Supplementary Material

A Appendix: Hungarian Context – Media Control

Recent developments indicate a further intensification of the government's efforts to consolidate control over the media and communication sectors. New legislation, introduced under the banner of "defending Hungary's sovereignty," has raised serious concerns about additional restrictions on press freedom.[33] At the same time, the government has continued expanding its influence over strategic industries, including telecommunications. In January 2023, Vodafone Hungary – the country's second-largest telecommunications provider, serving over 3.8 million customers – was acquired by a consortium in which local IT firm 4iG Nyrt. gained a 51% majority stake, while the Hungarian state obtained a 49% indirect share. This takeover represents one of the most significant state-influenced acquisitions in the media and communications sector to date (HVG 2023).

B Appendix: Experiment Design

- **Gender.** Candidate gender was randomly assigned: 78% of candidates were male and 22% female. These proportions were chosen to reflect the actual gender distribution of candidates in the elections.
- **Experience / competence.** We introduced random variation in candidates' experience and perceived competence. Sixty percent of candidates were described as inexperienced, meaning they had never held the office they were contesting. The remaining 40% had previous experience, evenly split between those with a positive (20%) and a negative (20%) performance record.
- **Supporting party.** Half of the candidates were supported by Fidesz, 25% by left-wing opposition parties, and 25% ran as independents.
- **Religiosity.** Candidates' religiosity was also varied. A quarter of the candidates were identified as atheists, and another 25% had no information provided about their religious beliefs. The remaining 50% were Christian: half of them (25%) were described as occasional attendees of religious services, and the other half (25%) as regular attendees.
- **Involvement in corruption.** We indicated whether candidates had previously been implicated in corruption. Half of all candidates were described as *clean*, with no history of corruption. The other half had been involved in some form of corrupt activity. Among these, half (25% of all candidates) were described as being *involved*

[33] In December 2023, the Hungarian Parliament adopted the so-called Sovereignty Protection Act alongside a related constitutional amendment. A statement by a media industry association argues that the law contradicts the spirit of the Fundamental Law and threatens press freedom by curbing the work of newsrooms, journalists, and media companies. It also warns that the Sovereignty Protection Office may target editorial teams based on vague and unspecified claims that their content poses a threat to Hungary's sovereignty (Cseke 2023).

just like many other politicians, while the other half (25%) were characterized as *involved unlike most other politicians*, allowing us to examine whether the perceived prevalence of corruption affects evaluations.

- **Source of Corruption Information.** For candidates involved in corruption, we also disclosed the source of the information. Possible sources included a court ruling or reports by one of four major media outlets—two under government control and two independent, selected for their large audience reach. For corrupt candidates not affiliated with Fidesz, each of the five sources had an equal probability of being cited (20%). For Fidesz-supported candidates, we excluded government-controlled media (which do not report on Fidesz-related corruption), assigning equal probabilities (33.3%) to the remaining three sources. Before the conjoint experiment, respondents were asked to assess the credibility of the media outlets and their trust in the independence of the courts. This enabled us to construct individual-level measures of perceived source credibility.

- **Form of Corruption and Side Benefit.** We also varied the nature of the corrupt act. There were five scenarios: one involved accepting a bribe of 10 million forints (approx. 25,000 USD). The other four involved selling public land to a friend at a below-market price. These varied by the extent of undervaluation (10 million vs. 100 million forints, or approx. 25,000 vs. 250,000 USD) and by what was built on the land—a private residence with no additional benefit, or a factory that created 120 new

C Appendix: Baseline Conjoint Estimates: Additional Results

Figure A1 modifies Figure 2 of the main text, by distinguishing between the cases when corruption is widespread or not. It shows that the estimated punishment is not statistically significantly different from each other: 23.3 percentage points when corruption is widespread and 23.1 percentage points when corruption is not widespread.

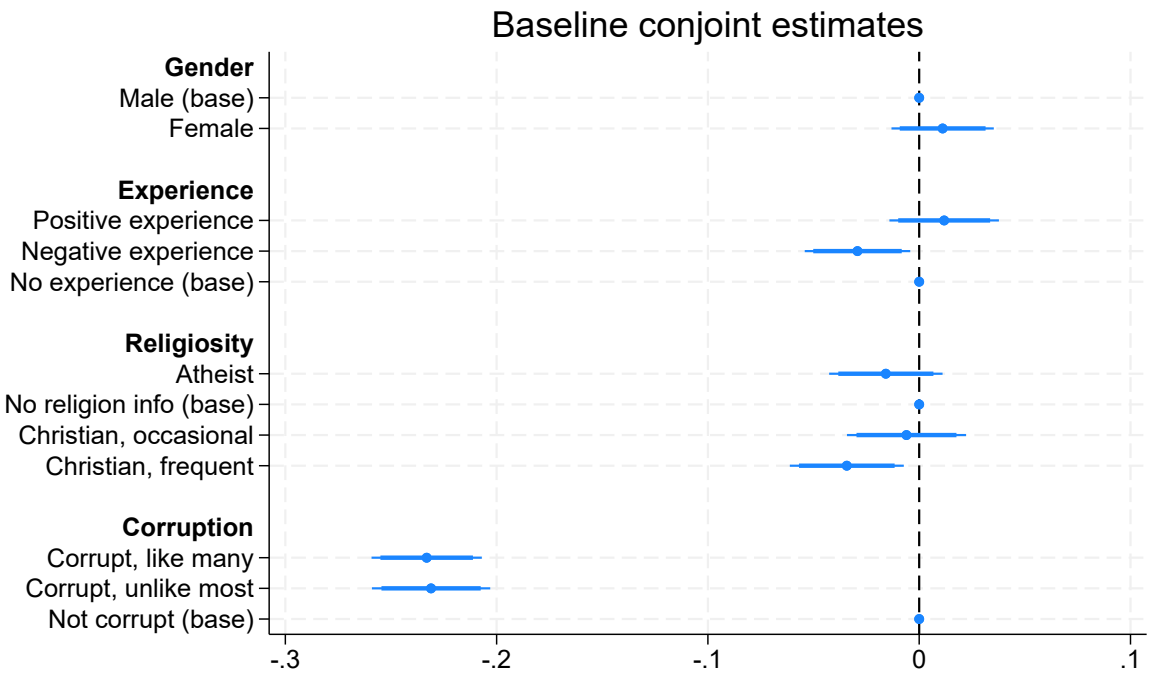

Figure A1: The effect of candidate attributes on the probability of being chosen—with a binary variable of being corrupt or not

Figure A2 replicates Figure 2 from the main text, with the addition of estimated parameters for party match – a binary variable indicating whether the candidate's party aligns with the respondent's preferred party. As expected, the coefficients are strongly positive and highly statistically significant.

Figure A3 shows the estimated effect of corruption when individual perceptions about the supporting party's corruption are also taken into account. We find that these individual perceptions are very important determinants of the vote probabilities: our point estimate is -20.8 percentage points, meaning that if the respondents perceives the supporting party of the candidate as "very corrupt", her voting probability decreases by 20.8 percentage points relative to the case when the individual perception about the supporting party is "not at all corrupt". However, in this specification the effect of the candidate being corrupt

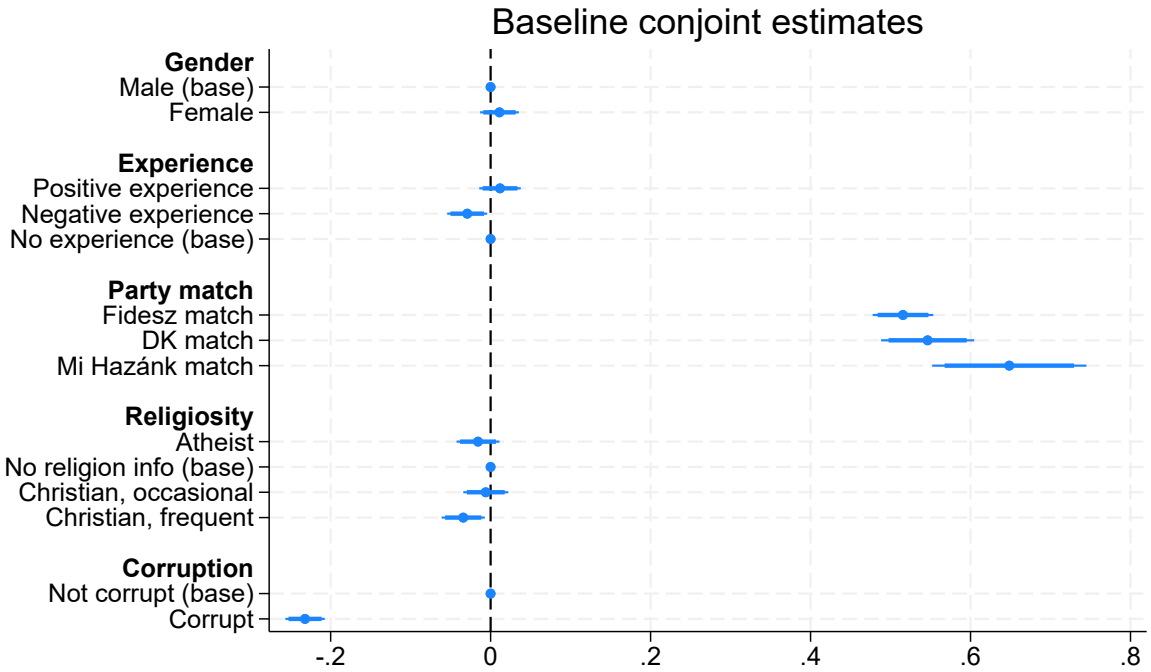

Figure A2: Effect of Candidate Attributes on Choice Probability: Full Set of Estimated Parameters

(-23.1 percentage points) is almost identical to the effect in our baseline specification (-23.2 percentage points).

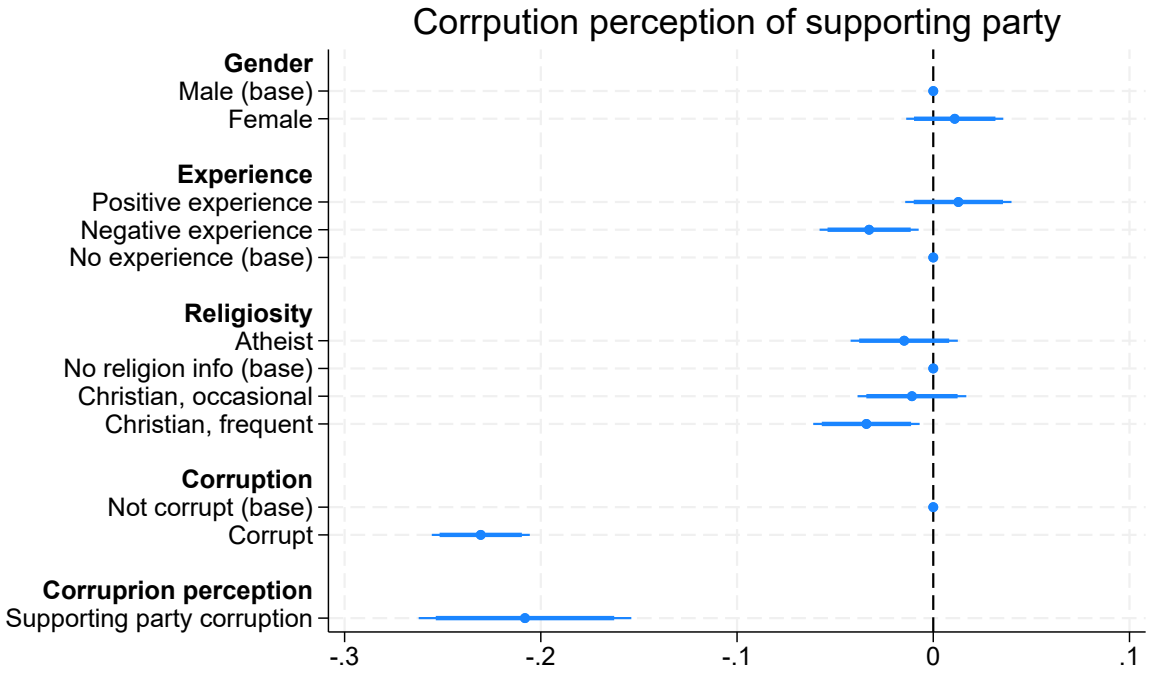

Figure A3: Effect of Perceptions on Supporting Party Corruption

D Appendix: Information Stage

D.1 Media Outlets and Media Consumption

Type of media	Pro-government	Government-critical	Other / Not political
TV channels	**M1 (public)** TV2 Hír TV	Euronews **RTL** ATV	
Radio stations	Kossuth (public)	Klubrádió	Petőfi Rádió 1 Retró Rádió Local radio Inforádió Karc FM
Online newspapers	**origo.hu**	24.hu **telex.hu** hvg.hu 444.hu	index.hu
Print newspapers	Magyar Nemzet Metró	Népszava	Blikk Bors Regional newspapers

Source: The "Other" category includes outlets that either do not focus on political content or cannot be clearly classified as pro-government or government-critical. This table follows the categorization of Mérték Media Monitor—an independent watchdog—which classifies outlets as either pro-government or government-critical (Mérték 2023).

Table A1: Media Outlets Included in the Survey, Classified by Type and Political Orientation

Figure A4 illustrates news consumption patterns across voter groups for the four media outlets featured in our conjoint experiment. Among these, M1 and origo.hu are Fidesz-controlled and are primarily consumed by Fidesz voters. In contrast, RTL and telex.hu—which are independent of government influence—are followed predominantly by opposition voters, with Fidesz supporters engaging with these outlets at rates well below the population average.

Additionally, Figures A6 and A7 disaggregate the overall media consumption patterns shown in Figure A5 by party preference. While the results indicate that Fidesz voters predominantly rely on Fidesz-controlled (pro-government) outlets and opposition voters primarily consume independent (government-critical) media, they also reveal a degree of cross-cutting media exposure. This suggests that, despite clear partisan tendencies, media consumption is not entirely confined to ideological information bubbles.

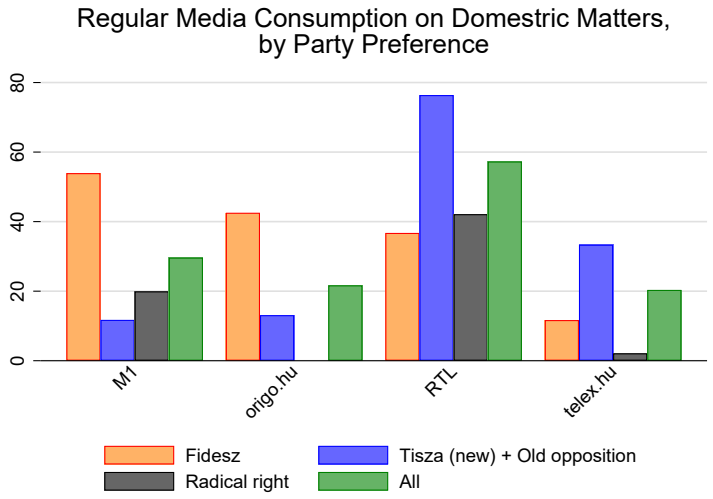

Figure A4: Regular Media Consumption by Party Preference

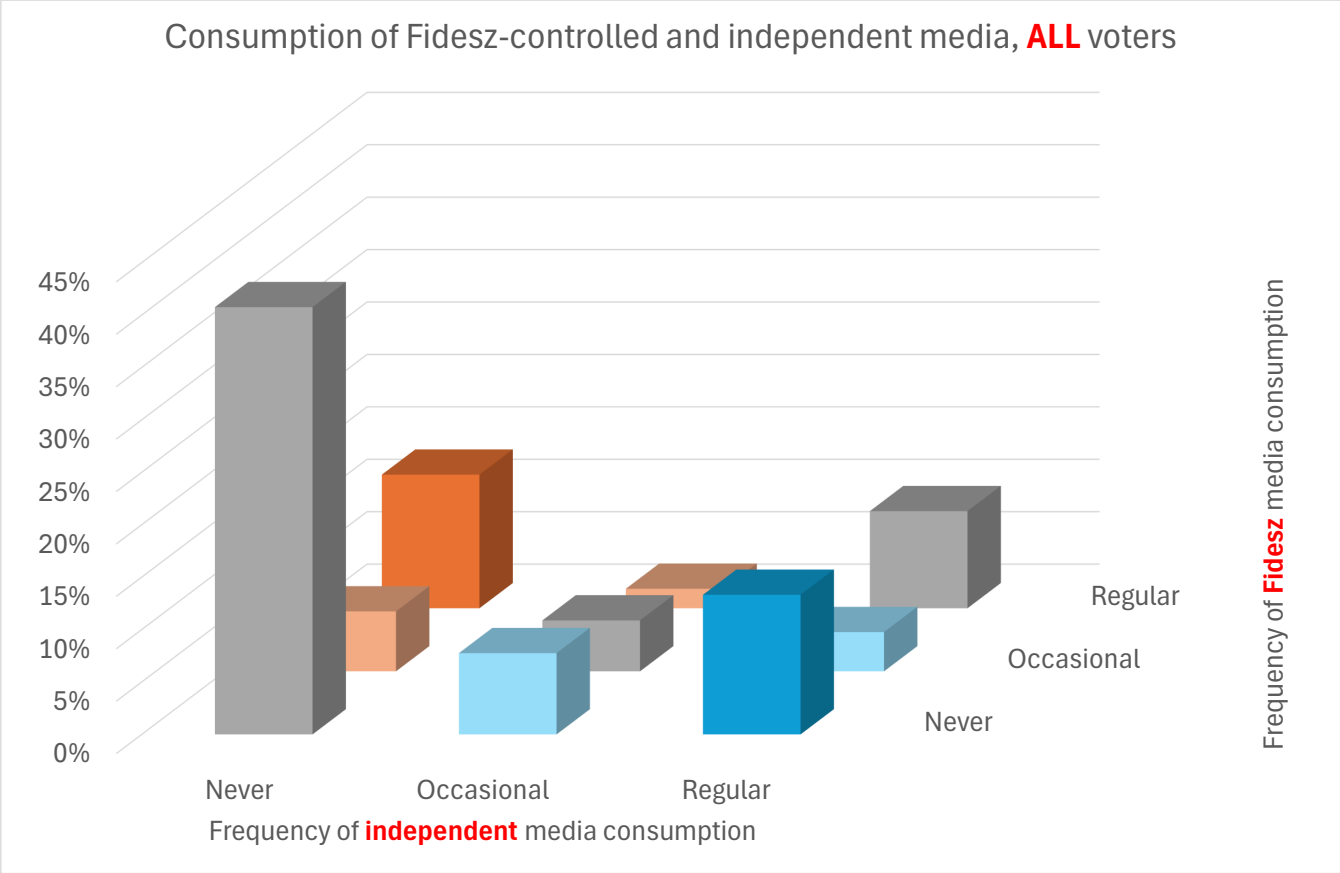

Figure A5: Consumption of Fidesz-controlled and Independent media (All Voters, %)

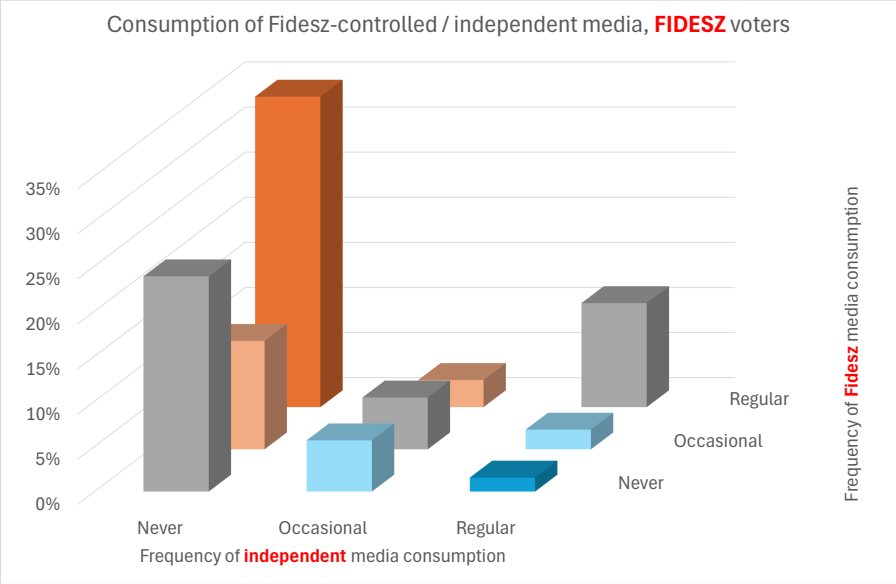

Figure A6: Consumption of Fidesz-controlled and independent media (Fidesz voters, %)

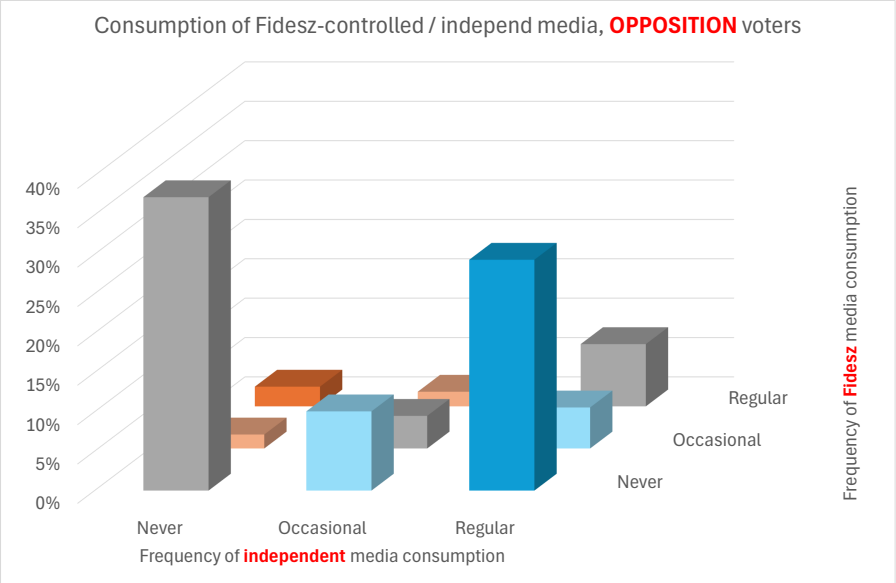

Figure A7: Consumption of Fidesz-controlled and independent media (opposition voters, %)

D.2 Media Credibility and Trust in Judicial Institutions

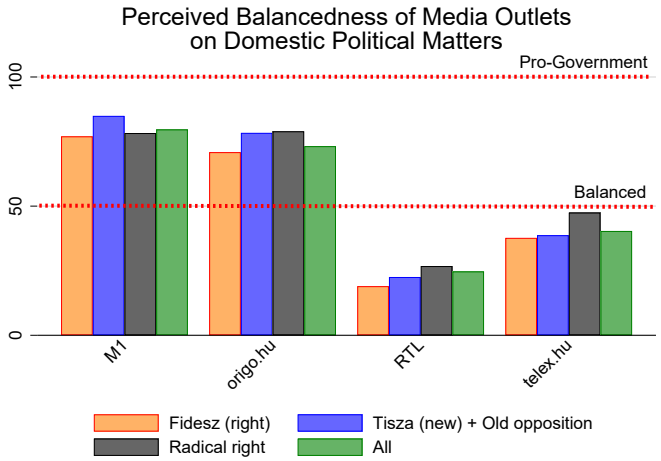

Figure A8: Perceived Balancedness of Media Outlets on Domestic Political Matters, by Party Preference

D.3 Source Credibility – Additional Evidence

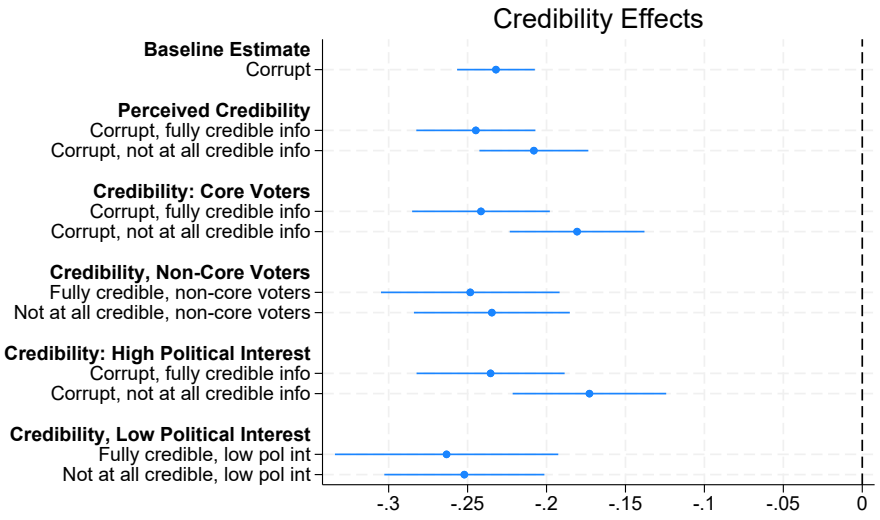

Figure A9: The Effect of Information Credibility on Voting for Corrupt Candidates, Moderated by Core Voter Status and Political Interest

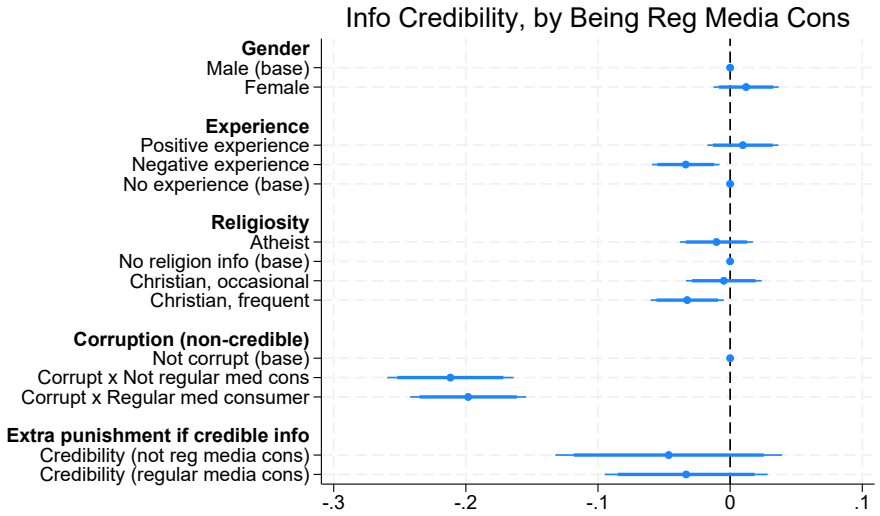

Figure A10: Information Credibility Effect by Frequency of Media Consumption

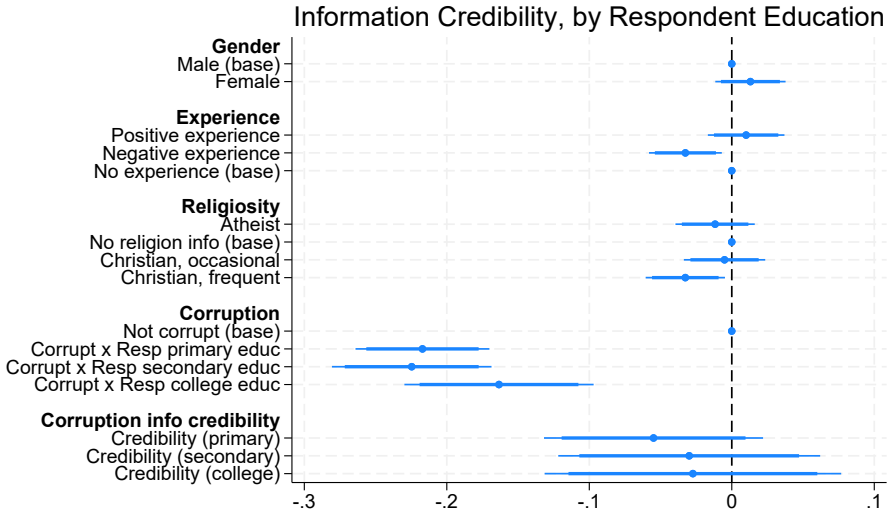

Figure A11: Information Credibility Effect by Education

E Appendix: Mitigating Condition

E.1 Social Group Identities

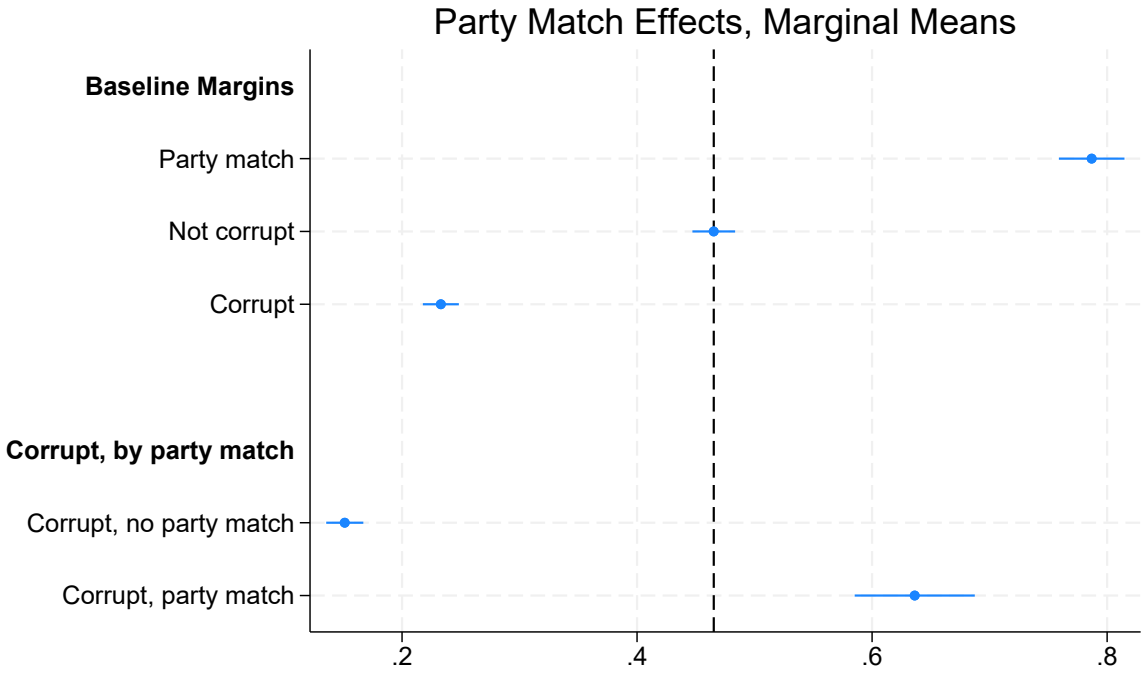

Figure A12: Corruption Punishment With and Without Party Match (Marginal Means)

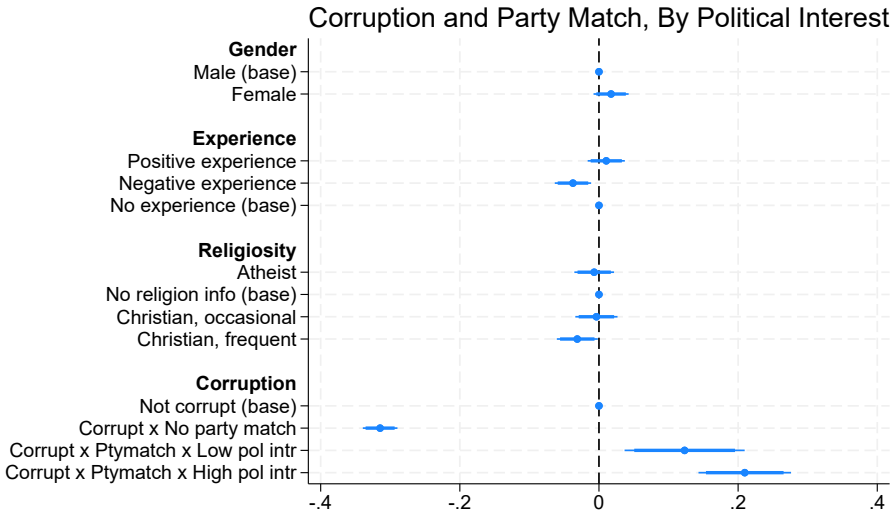

Figure A13: Corruption and Party Match, by Political Interest

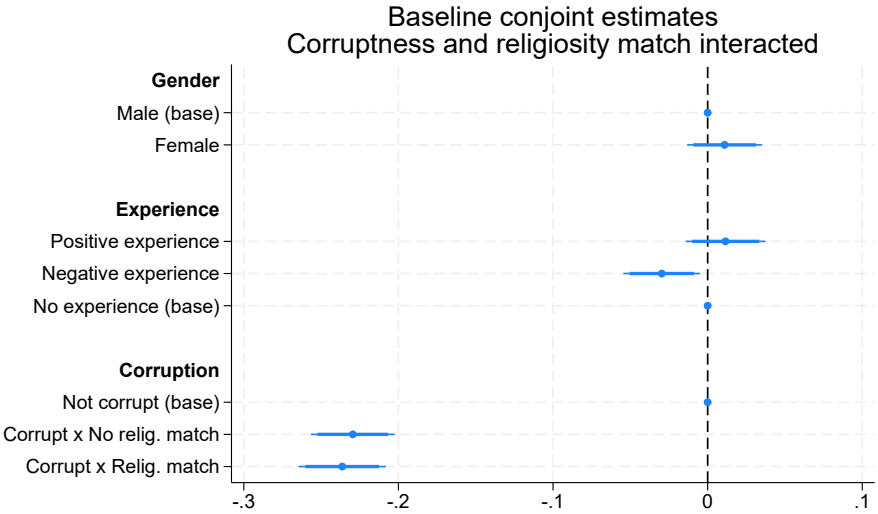

Figure A14: Religious Affiliation and Corruption Punishment

Note: All other coefficients are included in the model but omitted from the figure for clarity.

E.2 Instrumental Calculations

To assess how voters perceive the seriousness of different corruption cases, we asked respondents to rate five specific scenarios corresponding to those used in the conjoint experiment. Each respondent evaluated the seriousness of each case on a 0–10 scale, where 0 indicated "not at all serious" and 10 indicated "very serious."

As discussed in the main text, the first case involved a politician accepting a bribe of 10 million forints (approximately 25,000 USD). The remaining four concerned the underpriced sale of public land to a friend, varying in the amount of financial loss (10 million vs. 100 million forints) and in the outcome (construction of a private house vs. a factory creating 120 jobs).

Figure A15 shows that perceived seriousness is slightly lower when the corruption case includes a side benefit (i.e., job creation via a factory) or involves a smaller monetary loss. However, the differences are modest: average ratings across all five cases range from 8.2 to 9.1, suggesting that respondents regard all forms of corruption as highly serious. Perceptions are largely consistent across partisan groups, though supporters of the newly founded Tisza party—whose platform emphasizes anti-corruption—express slightly more severe evaluations.

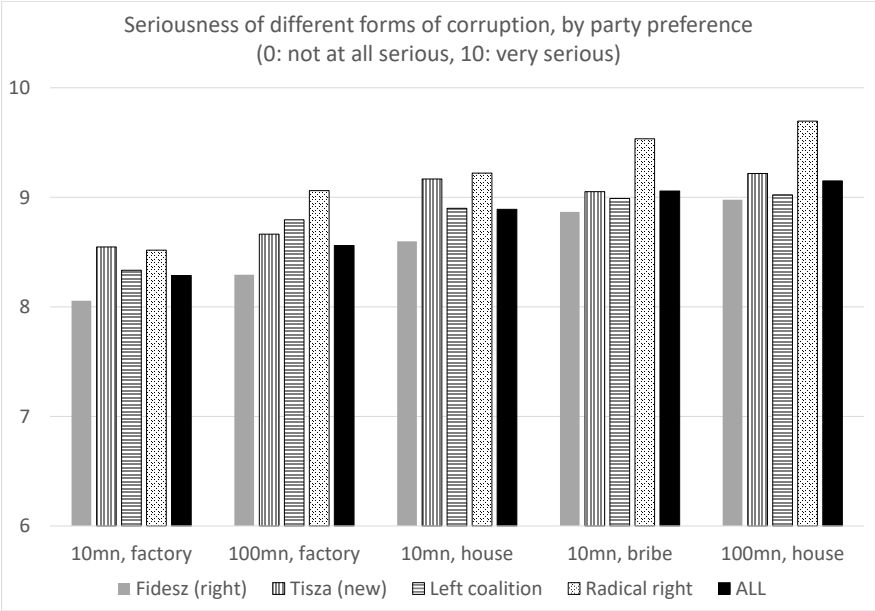

Figure A15: Seriousness of different types of corruption, by party preference

F Appendix: Behavioral Responses

F.1 Sticking

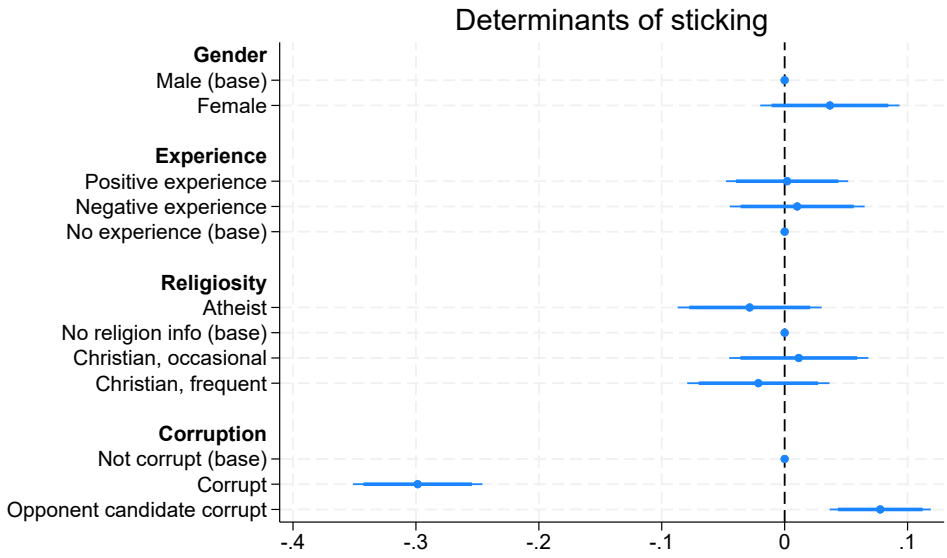

Figure A16: Determinants of Sticking: in-Group Candidates

Whether voters are willing to abandon their preferred candidate in the face of corruption depends in part on the availability of ideologically proximate alternatives. As argued by Charron and Bågenholm (2016), individuals' positions on the left–right ideological scale condition their likelihood of punishing corruption, particularly in party systems with a limited number of viable alternatives—such as the setting of our conjoint experiment. Using cross-national survey data from 24 European countries, including Hungary, they demonstrate that respondents at the ideological extremes (radical left or radical right) are significantly less likely to sanction corruption. This pattern reflects the relative scarcity of ideologically close but non-corrupt alternatives compared to those with centrist positions.

F.2 Abstention

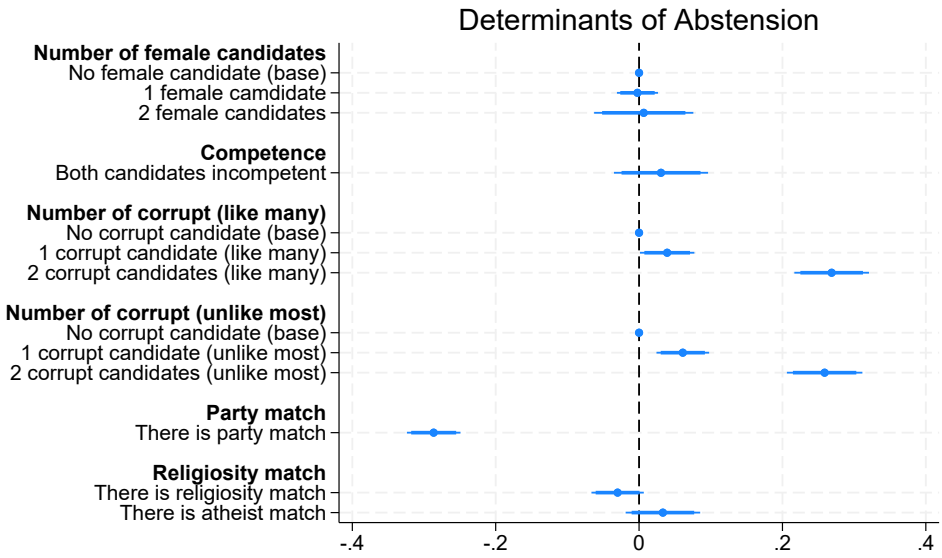

Figure A17: Determinants of Abstention–Candidate Characteristics

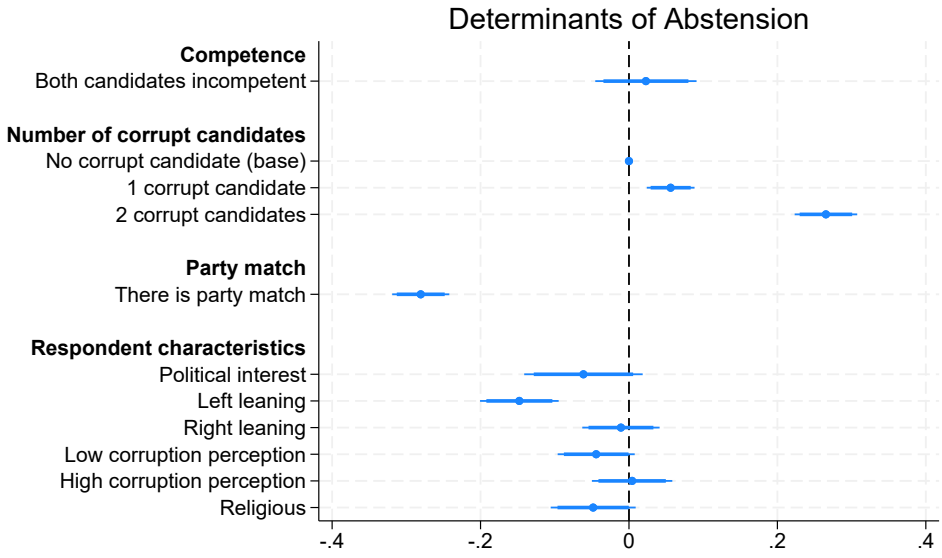

Figure A18: Determinants of Abstention–Voter Characteristics

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